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EDITOR'S NOTE

Change has always bemused me.

I would feel that life in KMLA was static. In a community that seems isolated from the outside world, where students follow rigorous routines, interact with the same people every day, and learn to embrace traditions, there are times that change feels like an illusion.

But there are also moments where I feel inundated by changes. Many will agree that the first semester of 2025 was a rather chaotic semester with countless, unexpected changes in policies and programs. Also at an individual level, in the three years we spend in this school, we are cultivating changes in our perspectives and in the people we become. Change will continue to bemuse me, as the new and the exotic continue to approach the old and the ordinary in unexpected ways.



In the 72nd edition, Minjok Herald delivers on the theme **"Ch-Ch-Ch-Changes,"** inspired by David Bowie's iconic single Changes. Even when school life–quizzes, deadlines, college applications–convince us otherwise, paying attention to the world around us remains essential. Because change doesn't just happen *to* us. It happens *through* us. Meanwhile, in the world beyond our campus, political, technological, and cultural shifts accelerate by the day, reshaping everything from how we learn to how we live our lives.

Through extensive research and reflection, each article explores how we adapt to, live with, or sometimes push back against changes.

A common thread of questions that tie them together are: **how do we find a crack in ordinary life? Stability in a life full of strife?** And most importantly, **how do we embrace and guide changes in a direction that doesn't leave anyone behind?**

Change, especially the kind that leaves the biggest impact, doesn't happen alone. The winter that I became Editor-in-Chief, I devoured every past Minjok Herald edition I could find, overwhelmed by the newfound responsibility. Thankfully, the past gave me a clearer vision of where to embrace convention and where to strive for innovation. But it was this year's Minjok Herald crew that brought the vision to reality.

What you're about to read is a work of collective hope: a belief that by paying attention to changes both big and small, we can spark conversations that matter. Now, dear readers, as David Bowie once said, we invite you to **turn these pages around and face the strange.**

28th Editor-in-Chief,
Hyunseo Lee

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A *CRACK* IN THE ORDINARY WORLD

Every change begins with the tiniest crack.
From major faculty changes to changes in the Vision Trip, as well as the **Heroes of Minsa Specials**, we track little breadcrumbs in our daily lives that are worth looking back at -- with some twists and turns.

Welcome, KMLA Family!

Mr. Jaegil Kim | Mr. Changgeun Song | Mr. Dongho Park
Mr. Changyoun Lee | Mr. Sangrae Kim

Heroes of Minsa: Specials

Introduction to Hero's Journey
The Freshmen's Journey
Heroes of Minsa: Founder Myungjae Choi
Heroes of Minsa: Dorm Father Daeki Kim

Looking Back on Teachers' Day

Mrs. Helen Jeong's Years at and after KMLA

KMLA's First Full-Scale UK University Fair:

From Sticky Pudding to Long-Term Partnerships

Vision Trip Specials

East Coast | West Coast



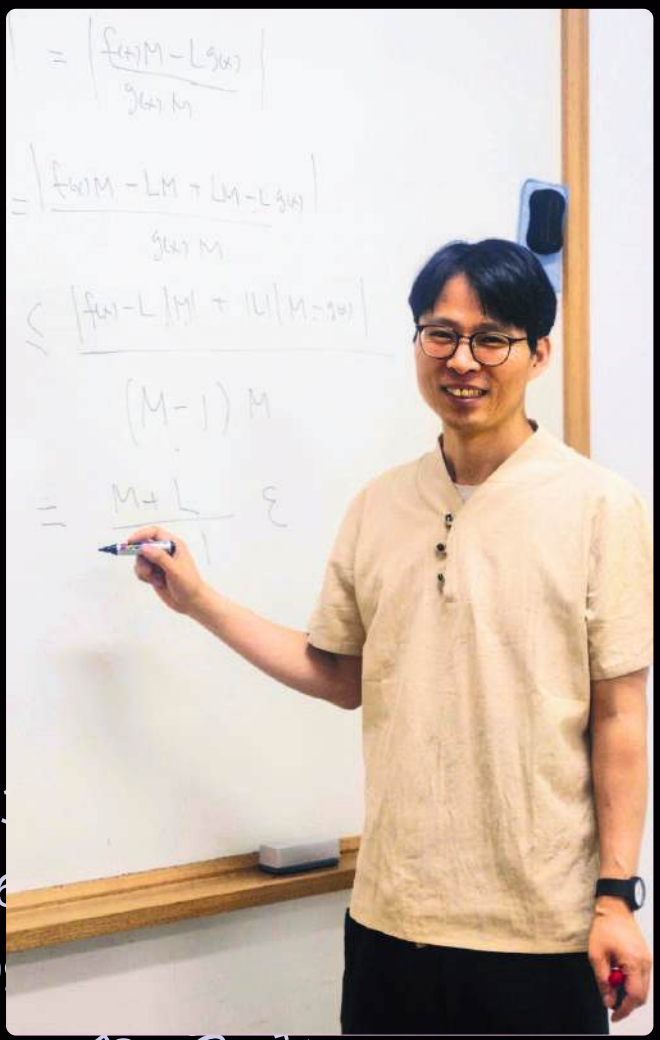
Welcome, KMLA Family!

At KMLA, it's not just the students who come and go. Our faculty changes, too. While we bid goodbyes to several beloved teachers last year, this semester brought many new faces to our school community.

In this edition, Minjok Herald sat down with six new teachers for interviews. We hope they offer a glimpse into their unique life experiences and perspectives, and perhaps reveal sides you haven't seen yet.

Mr. Jaegil Kim,
The New Mathematics Teacher

Interview by Rachel Chaewon Ahn



"As I mentioned during that lecture, Pi Day wasn't a thing when I was a student. It's a relatively new tradition. But I really like how it's become a part of student culture now—transforming math from something that feels rigid or difficult into something more approachable and fun. I just love that shift. So I wanted to share that experience with my students. That was a big part of the motivation behind doing something for Pi Day."

MH: This is a bit of a fun question. In math, we often deal with addition, subtraction, multiplication, and division. If you were to pick one of those operations to represent yourself, which would you choose, and why?

"Oh, that's a tough one! But I think I'd pick addition. Addition is all about taking things step by step, gradually building up. Multiplication might seem faster, but depending on the context, it can also lead to something close to zero. I like the steady progress that addition represents. Slowly but surely moving forward—that feels like a good fit for me."

Mr. Changgeun Song,
The New Economics Teacher
Interview by Hyunseo Lee

"The charm of economics? I believe economics is the study of human decision-making. Because of that, anything related to people can become a subject of economic research. Decisions are something we make constantly in our lives. So, in a very simple sense, learning how to make wiser decisions in life is what economics teaches us. I think that economics is the fastest and most practical path to understanding good decision-making.



Many students probably worry about choosing a career path, whether they've already decided or are still unsure. . . . In my case, I once seriously considered changing my major after getting a D in my first economics course in college. But after coming back from military service, I took another economics class that was so fascinating, it completely changed how I saw the subject. The class that made me truly love economics was Microeconomics. It was so interesting that I kept studying and eventually went to graduate school, where I chose the same professor who taught that course as my advisor. I earned my master's degree under his guidance. Now, I teach AP Microeconomics and Intermediate Microeconomics myself, using my own approach based on what I learned from that class.
So don't worry too much if you're unsure. Even if you've already chosen a path but feel uncertain, that's also okay. Sometimes, the right interest or inspiration comes later."

Mr. Changyoun Lee,
The New Chemistry Teacher
Interview by Jeongmin Lee

"I want to help students find joy in science through my classes. I have a goal to accumulate a hundred entries to research competitions within five years, with students who love science. A hundred on the record means to me that I will foster a hundred brilliant scientists. I want to grow a hundred good-hearted and brilliant, skillful scientists at KMLA.

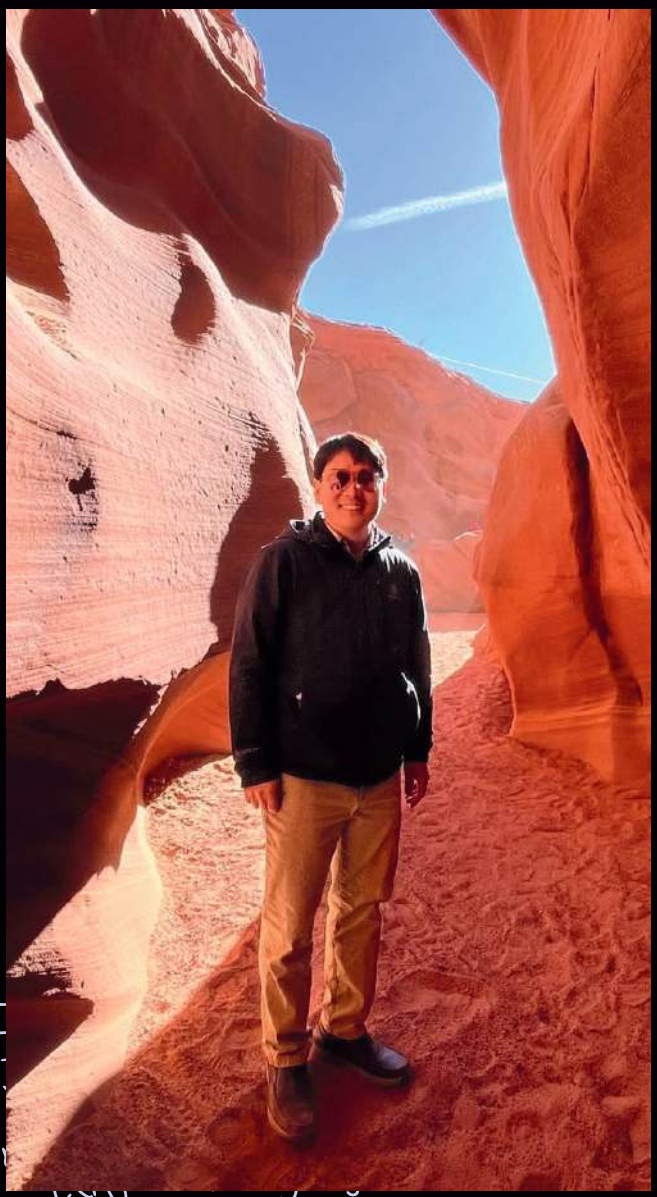
When learning chemistry, I want students to know that grades are only numbers, and are not a representation of their worth. Wouldn't it be nice to think of the numbers on your report cards as something like a record of your biorhythm that specific exam day? Grades do matter. You have to study efficiently and do your best to reach your goal. What I want to say is that having bad grades doesn't mean you have to feel beaten down. I hope that you will become someone that, at times of despair, chooses to try twice, three times more. I will always be rooting for you!"

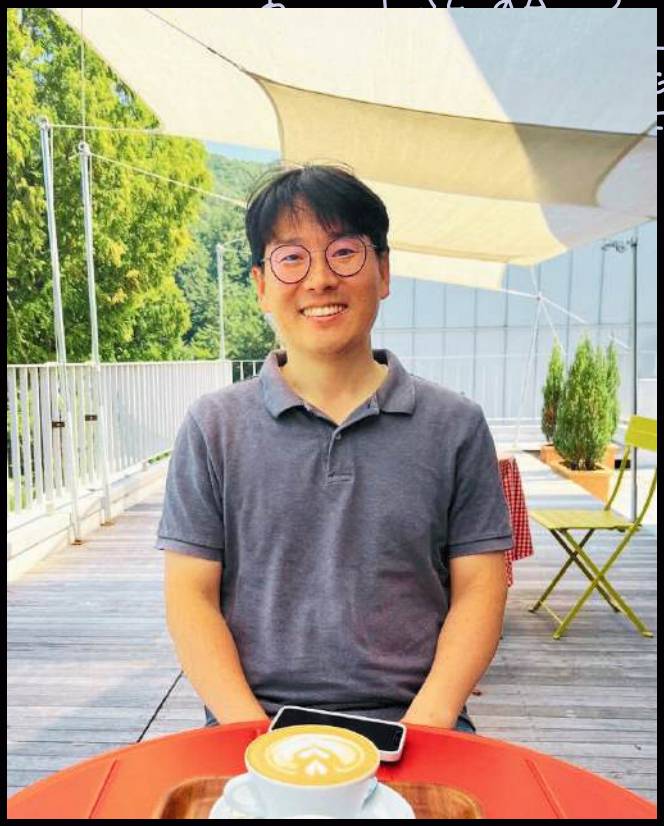


Mr. Dongho Park,
The New Physics Teacher

Interview by Minju Kim

“In middle school, I was very focused on things I loved, but in high school, I started losing that focus. Only later did I realize that maintaining passion is crucial. Look at Einstein—he succeeded because he focused on the research he was passionate about, despite not having the best grades. So, I hope KMLA students find subjects they truly enjoy and pursue them with dedication and happiness. . . .





To talk about my first research in string theory, I was fascinated by the mathematical nature of physical laws, which sparked my love for quantum field theory and string theory. . . . Eventually, I shifted my focus to Einstein’s theory of relativity, coding partial differential equations for simulations. As I learned more programming, I used simulation techniques extensively and incorporated particle theory into my work, ultimately earning my PhD degree.

Afterward, I explored research on supernovae. I collaborated with the Biophysics group at POSTECH’s Asia Pacific Center for Theoretical Physics where I conducted various simulations and research projects. Over time, I felt a growing pull back toward education. The challenges I experienced in theoretical physics made me want to support students by sharing those lessons. Though I didn’t plan to return to teaching immediately, I found my way back through various opportunities, and I now teach at KMLA.”

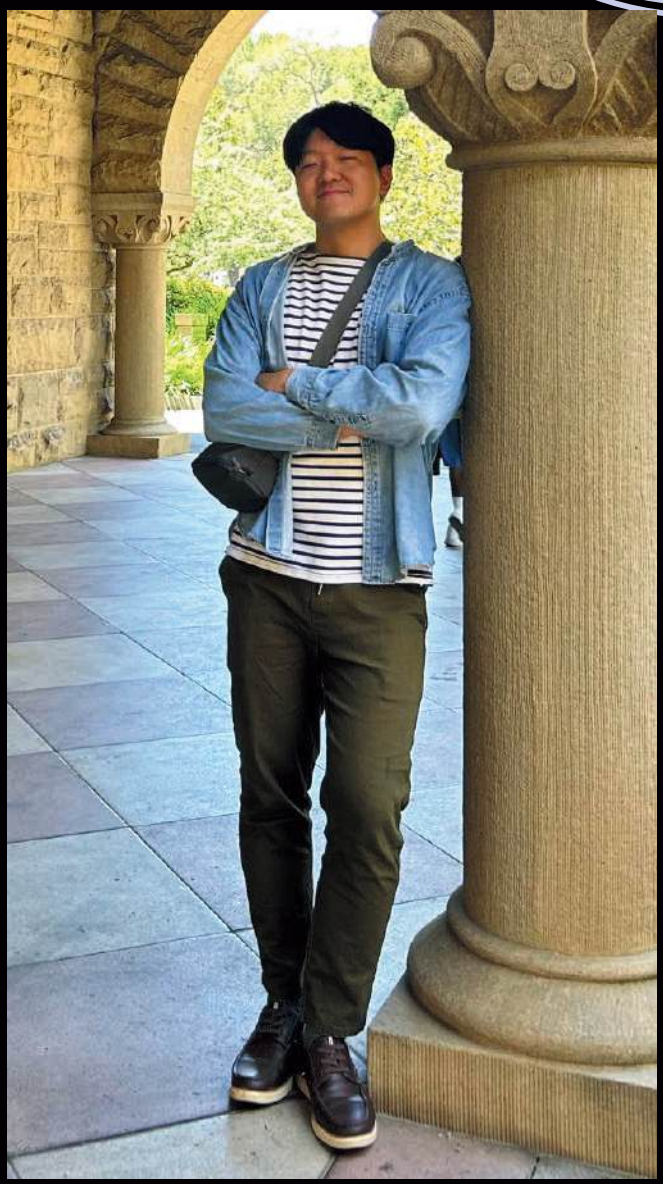
Mr. Sangrae Kim,
The New Social Studies Teacher

Interview by Jiseo Lee

"I've always liked acting like I know things — in fact, that's the primary reason that drew me to teaching. One of the greatest joys of being a teacher is getting to share knowledge with others, especially when they don't know something yet, and I've enjoyed that since I was young. There's also a certain sense of superiority or catharsis that comes from teaching — the classroom often feels like a stage to me. Overall, I find a great deal of satisfaction in this job.

But still, it's true that there's still something I need to improve on as a teacher: caring for students. A teacher's role isn't just to teach, but also to care. That means noticing when students are struggling, responding to their emotional needs, and being there for them is important., I'm still learning how to do that properly. I want to be remembered as someone who is not just smart, but also warm — and while I believe I'm smart enough for a teacher, I'm not always sure I'm warm enough. . . .





Every week, I write a short note for my homeroom, 10th grade Class 9 students — and in one of them, I shared something that I want to tell you all: You don't have to be so tense. You don't have to be dramatic about everything. It's okay if your grades drop. It's okay if you disappoint the adults around you. Disappointing them doesn't mean you'll lose their love. You're still growing, and that's more than enough."



Heroes of Minsa : Specials

Introduction to The Hero's Journey
from Mr. Garrioch

"One of the most rewarding experiences I've recently had at KMLA was teaching every 30th Wave freshman during orientation. With only three lessons to plan, I asked myself: what's one thing I wish someone had taught me in high school? It was the Hero's Journey, or what Joseph Campbell called the monomyth.

I didn't learn about it until I spent a year (and too much money) in film school. I didn't end up in Hollywood, but I walked away with two lessons: structure matters, and the Hero's Journey can unlock not just stories—but life. And the best part? You don't need a sword or a villain. You just need to see how structure and content shape each other.

As a literature teacher who also coaches public speaking and essays, I've come to see storytelling everywhere—from Netflix shows set in Jeju to personal statements that get students into Stanford. Even nature tells stories. The caterpillar becomes a butterfly. The student becomes the hero.

We all walk through an Inmost Cave. We all face dragons. And if we're lucky, we come out the other side with some new truth. An exam doesn't define you. A failure isn't final—it's just a passage. No Elixir yet? That's okay. You'll find it. With time. With hindsight. With insight. It's supposed to be this way. Sometimes, heroes need to suffer. Step one of being human.

So, without further ado, let us read and enjoy these honest interpretations from the Heroes of Minsa—brave freshmen in their brave new world—sharing their take on each stage of the journey.

From 150 submissions, I selected those that, together, form an honest and cohesive portrait of Campbell's timeless path. My hope? That every KMLA student, regardless of wave, sees something of themselves in these stories.



Heroes of Minsa: The Freshmen's Journey

Ordinary World
by 30th Waver Yuhoon Jang

My ordinary world is a rural village, located on the northeastern side of the Korean peninsula, in Gangwon province. With the picturesque mountains of Seorak and the vast waters of the East Sea, it sometimes seems like the background of a Ghibli movie.
Although I was born in this mother-nature environment, I would describe my life before coming to KMLA to be “mundane” and “boring.” Riding the bus 40 minutes every day... back and forth to my class consisting of only 10 students... getting in my mom's car for an hour-long ride to go to a hagwon every Saturday... ending the week with church. A pretty dull life. As a venturesome person, I craved for a breakthrough that would alter my repetitive life.
Although there’s a plethora of reasons why I applied to KMLA, in retrospect, I think seeking a “breakthrough” is the biggest reason.

Call to Adventure
by 30th Waver Rua Kim

Our protagonist, a creature of habit and questionable snack choices, was living a life of blissful mediocrity. With vague concerns about deadlines and above-average grades, she could very easily justify the past hour of doom scrolling. It was just as her thumb hovered over the illuminated screen, and begged to imprint itself on just one more wasted moment, that a dragon’s head pushed itself through the bedroom window and shattered the glass. Our protagonist was so surprised that she - What? A dragon? Yes. A real dragon. A huge red one - that she immediately hunted for a baseball bat to whack it on the head. However, the beast was faster, and swiftly handed the dumbfounded girl a letter - bearing the pink wax seal of KMLA. And then the dragon wished her a brief “Good luck” and was gone from where it came. She hesitated before tearing it open. It read - “You’ve been accepted.”

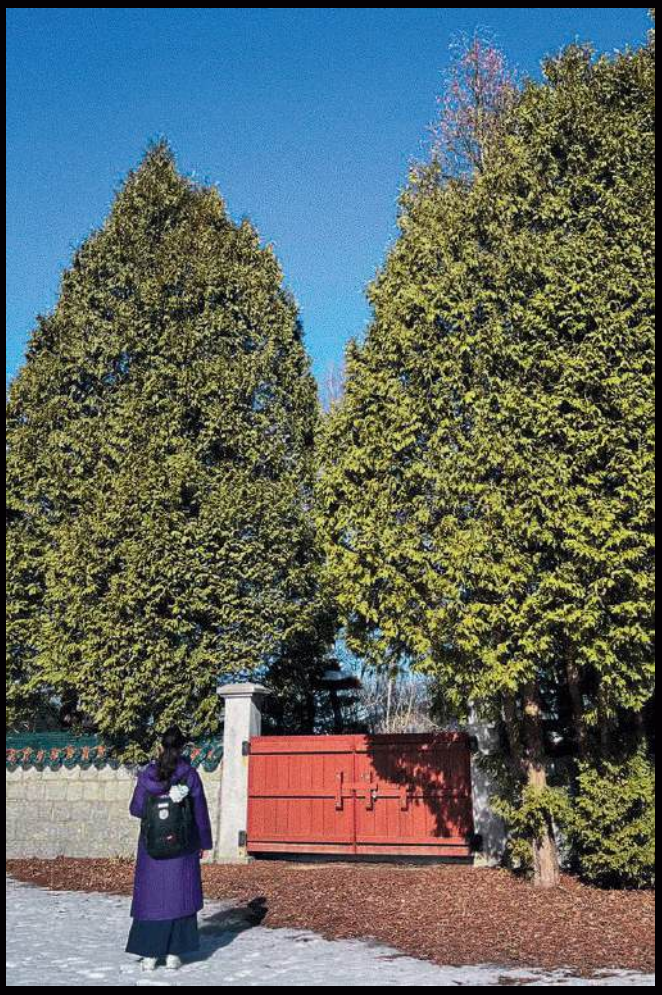




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Refusal of the Call
by 30th Waver Sewon Park

I suppose the Orientation is "Refusal of the Call" for most of us 30th Wavers. Especially as we continually fail everything from club interviews to quizzes. I failed or probably did poorly in several. I'm trying to cope with failure by having hope and belief in myself; however, it's hard when the universe is sending me the message "not good enough" over and over again. But I've been at this stage before and then responded by trying even harder. Sometimes I even ace the exam or succeed far more than expected. At the very least I learn something. It's a difficult stage, but I think the solution is clear: believe in yourself and stop underestimating. The Refusal of the Call will lead to success as long as you don't "refuse" yourself.



Meeting the Mentor
by 30th Waver Jaemin Shim

In my life, I used to feel that there was no one I could call a genuine "Mentor." So I'm seeking my mentor to help my journey towards success by thinking about it in a more objective way. "Mentor" should have no limits. A "mentor" can be a teacher, a student, or even an animal. If there's some point to learn from them, they're a mentor. In KMLA, there's so many different people with different perspectives. In this ecosystem, I hope I can learn how to embrace others. This can show KMLA itself as a "Mentor." I hope this north star leads me to the top of the mountain.



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4

Crossing the Threshold

by 30th Waver Jiseo Lee

As she walked down the winding road ahead of her, the girl looked up at the two statues that stood their ground, guarding the school. She couldn’t help but feel as if the statues were glancing back down at her. ‘No, that cannot be,’ she thought. The statues stood gigantic. Cold. Even indifferent. They certainly didn't move. But at the same time, their gaze somehow felt consoling and merciful, and it put the girl at ease. She didn't know what to name this undecided feeling, but as she walked forward, she decided not to force any hasty interpretations onto what mysterious emotion she would be feeling for the next 3 years.

So there she went. Through the gates, past the statues, onto a new chapter of her life. Not knowing that this experience would change her life forever.



Tests, Allies and Enemies

by 30th Waver Minseo Lee

I've heard that the tests we take in this high school are vastly different from the ones we were accustomed to in the past. These exams are designed to challenge not only our academic knowledge but also the way we think, encouraging us to approach problems from unique and creative perspectives. The curriculum we take doesn't just focus on memorization or conventional learning; instead, it pushes us to think outside the box and constantly strive to exceed our limits.

In my opinion, my peers here are not only intelligent but also hard-working and motivated. I feel that I can connect with them on a deeper level, discussing ideas, topics, and sharing our stories, etc., which I never got to in middle school. I haven't encountered enemies yet. However, having some form of healthy competition intrigues me.



Approach to Inmost Cave

by 30th Waver Jaewook Choi

What I can remember most clearly is the memory of the KMLA interview. Until approaching this darkest cave, I'd never been so nervous in my life. Heart beat echoing in my ears. "His palms are sweaty, knees weak, arms are heavy." I used to dream that I got into the interview room and responded so confidently that I mesmerized the teachers. Nevertheless, I knew that this was not me as the protagonist in the real world, and the playing field was fair. In reality, my dream was collapsing for 13 minutes while struggling to answer. Reality betrayed me again and again, even many days after the longest 13 minutes of my life. The cave seemed to be never-ending. I met a giant monster named Anxiety in that cave. At the time, I was almost destroyed. But suddenly, sunlight hit the cave and the monster vanished. That's the way I finally entered KMLA.



Ordeal

by 30th Waver Minyoung Jung

This school has been a huge challenge for me. It's a completely different environment from the one I've lived in, and even that was difficult for me. I came to this school because I wanted to study more, even if the rewards aren't instant or easily visible. After I came here, I realized that I am still lacking in many ways, and these feelings make things hard for me. These feelings will continue to give me despair, but every time they do I'll turn to the belief that I will grow through this process. Even if I fall, I will keep falling down with a smile and strive for growth. I feel like I am in a lot of trouble right now, but I don't think this has to be a bad thing. Anyway, I am in the adventure and this is something to be thankful for, and this is a happy thing. I will keep falling down, trying my best to enjoy the process, and trying my best to grow up.



Reward

by 30th Waver Jeongeun Lee

On Monday, I went to a tryout at the archery field and saw a small group of students chatting. Gathering my courage, I introduced myself, and soon we were talking about where we are from and what majors we have chosen. At first, it felt a bit awkward, but as we discovered similar interests, our conversations became more natural. I realized that if we take the first step and show interest in others, it naturally leads to meaningful connections. I hope that this experience helps me navigate new social environments in the future.



The Road Back

by 30th Waver Gahyeon Ryu

It's finally Friday. I run to school on the exact same path as always. I hear the school bell ring, but I'm not there yet. "Well, I guess straight-to-the-auditorium it is," I murmur to myself. Late? Definitely not something the three-years-ago me would expect from herself. Something else that is also different - flower sellers at front gate. This is not just any school day. Yes, it happens to be graduation day.

Thankfully, nothing's started yet. I get in. Get ready. The ceremony eventually begins, and ends just as quickly. We take pictures in the yard. I look for my friends. Also something the three-years-ago me would never do.

Then it suddenly starts snowing. I honestly didn't miss snow, but I know I'm going to miss everything else. Still, I'm calm and without worries. Because I also know this isn't our last goodbye.



Resurrection

by 30th Waver Junghoo Park

Becoming a KMLA student had been my biggest wish for the past few years. I still can't forget the first moment I arrived at school last year. I was indescribably happy back then. However, soon enough the life here in KMLA stressed me out more than I could've imagined. I felt like I didn't fit in, and I couldn't follow the intense schedule. Over the six months at school, I struggled with health issues, an overloaded schedule, and depression. So, taking some time off from school was my final option. Although there were times I regretted my choice, I achieved a lot during my six months of rest. I had the chance to look at my problems from a third-person perspective. Now I know how to deal with stress, truly care for others (that doesn't mean I didn't care before taking time off), manage my time, and stand on my own. Some might say I wasted a year for nothing, but I know that 2024 was the most meaningful year of my life so far.



Return With The Elixir

by KMLA Senior

The senior climbs a few awkward steps onto the stage, careful not to trip on the hem of the silk graduation hanbok—a shimmering blend of royal blue and ruby red. Before them, a sea of gushing parents. Behind -, a long line of fluttering friends, waiting to hear their names, to clutch their diplomas. It all feels surreal.

This will be the senior's last time on this raised platform. They remember singing and dancing to BLACKPINK at a Christmas party. Stumbling through a speech during the 36th Student Council Election. Standing right there, cello in hand, as Waltz No. 2 made fingers bleed the week before the annual concert. Over three years, this stage has seen them terrified, exhilarated, bored.



What's this feeling now? Acceptance? Conclusion? Wisdom? No need to define it. Not yet.

The senior suddenly realizes it's best to just "live the moment"—this last moment. Last moment of high school. Last moment of a temporary community saying a temporary goodbye to a place they've loved, hated, and loved again over the past thousand days. Days of suffering, crying, laughing, singing, aching, memorizing, forgetting. Living.

Synecdoches and soliloquies. The derivative of e^x is just e^x, again. Words like ephemeral and obsequious that the senior has yet to use in casual conversation. Maybe someday.

Do we remember more than we forget? The senior won't forget—this.

Heroes of Minsa: Founder Choi Myungjae

Dongjae Ko

Every morning at 6 a.m., the halls of Deokgo House come alive with wake-up alarms ringing left and right. Students hurry to morning exercise, then to classes, following a schedule that has defined this school for decades. But how many of us pause to ask: who created this reality we go through every day?

When we get accepted to KMLA and move in, we receive books about the man and his life. But what do we do? We skim through some pages, leave it on our bookshelf, unopened until we graduate.
Yet behind that name lies a story of audacious dreams and relentless determination that shaped not just our school, but challenged an entire nation's approach to education and manufacturing milk.

This is the story of a man who abandoned security for possibility, who saw potential where others saw only problems. From a comfortable bank job to the driver's seat of a taxi, from the deserts of the Middle East to the dairy farms of Gangwon-do, Choi Myungjae's path to educational innovation was anything but conventional. His story begins with a choice that shocked everyone who knew him: the decision to leave everything behind in pursuit of something greater.

Departure: From Comfort into Greatness

Choi Myung-Jae, son of the founder of Jang-Hung Elementary School, and grandson of an education fanatic, was an avid believer in education from a young age. He took this to heart, getting accepted to, but dropping out of Seoul National University after migrating to Busan because of the Korean War. He soon began working at a bank, a dream job for many.

He had a well-paying and stable job. But it was still not enough to support his family. He thought about becoming a self-owned business owner. And his way of becoming one?

He decided to quit the bank and start again as a taxi driver.

His family was outraged. He had attended a top school; a stable job. Surely he didn't have all the money in the world, but his job was definitely among the cream of the crop, in the economic hellhole that was the 1950s of war-torn Korea. Hadn't he already won life? What more could he want?
But he was an ambitious man, and he had to do this.



Initialization: Milking Cars

He started small with a company-owned car. He worked tirelessly, memorizing every route, the most profitable hours for every location, for up to 20 hours a day. In less than 2 years, he had earned enough money to buy his own car. After 4 years, five cars. He had profited more from his 6 years in the taxi business than his 7 years at the bank. With his business expanding and thriving, he looked for international opportunities, and succeeded, meeting a friend from college who introduced him to oilfield logistics in the 1974 Okinawa industrial conference.

While the Iranians were initially skeptical, his crew's exceptional performance quickly earned the trust of local oil barons. This success was short-lived, however, when one of his employees slyly took Choi's position, leaving him behind.

Although the business was taken away, Choi was undeterred. Opportunities came and went in his mind, and one remained: land. He believed land was the source of all power, the wellspring of riches. He realized this when he saw former U.S. president Ronald Reagan wearing a cowboy hat and enjoying his vacation on a ranch in Palm Springs. At that moment he understood that America's strength did not come from ICBMs, nukes, or computers, but from agricultural supremacy. He began his quest in Gangwon-do with a dream in mind and determination in his heart.

Then, he came across Kuniki Saito, author of 'Real Milk'. What he learned was that UHT processing uses extremely high temperatures that denature milk proteins, destroy beneficial bacteria, and create a "cooked" taste, essentially turning fresh milk into what critics call over-processed, nutritionally inferior "fake" milk. He was ready to become the revolutionary of the milk industry; a pioneer of milk pasteurization, departing from the prevalent method of UHT (Ultra-High Temperature) processing to low-temperature pasteurization.

Gangwon-do, the heart of Korea, would be his base of operations. Milk production went well at first. But industry giants were bothered by his aggressive marketing, which labeled his milk "real" and theirs "fake." Even the government intervened, accusing Choi's company of false advertising. Sales, which had been skyrocketing, suddenly plummeted. The public believed his milk was an overpriced scam feeding on the fear of missing out, and Choi a fraud behind the helm. To counter the bad publicity, he purchased full-page newspaper ads to defend his position. Sales rebounded sharply, and public sentiment improved. Pasteur Milk persevered.

Through his several ventures and explorations, Choi had gained a substantial amount of wealth. Thus, the time had come for him to achieve his long-awaited dream: offering an institute of education beyond anything South Korea had ever seen.



The Return of The Elixir: KMLA Built

Nestled in the expansive woodlands of Hoengseong, Gangwon Province, a state-of-the-art educational facility is to be established. Each grade will consist of approximately 30 students, maintaining an exceptional student-to-teacher ratio of 3 to 1. Admission will follow a rigorous selection process designed to identify gifted individuals. Rejecting rote memorization, the curriculum will instead cultivate creativity and independent thought.
The overarching goal is to nurture individuals who are globally knowledgeable yet deeply rooted in their national identity. To this end, the school will integrate forward-looking, creative education with instruction in Korea's rich cultural traditions, fostering a harmonious blend of modernity and heritage.

- Choi, Myung-jae. Speak After 20 Years.
Seoul, Morning Nation Publishing, 2004, p. 189.



With its unique yet intuitive curriculum, the school began to show remarkable results and international recognition, one of the most notable being Dong-sun Hu's gold medal in the International Physics Olympiad in 1999.
Choi Myung-Jae passed away of old age on June 16, 2022, aged 95. With his death he left the school to his eldest son, Choi Gyung-Jong.
Even after the founder's death, KMLA continues its legacy of innovative and avant-garde education. KMLA ended up being one of the early pioneers against the Korean educational trend of machine-like rote memorization, creating the path where the original and the passionate thrive.



Transforming this educational vision into reality proved far more challenging than anticipated. Choi expected the government to welcome his investment of hundreds of billions of won in education. To his surprise, officials nitpicked on details like the school's name and created bureaucratic obstacles.

Parents presented an equally frustrating barrier. Their singular obsession with Seoul National University admission rates blinded them to Choi's broader educational philosophy. While he envisioned cultivating well-rounded global citizens, they demanded nothing more than test score factories.

The fundamental dysfunction of South Korea's education system created a perfect storm of confusion. As criticism mounted and public confidence wavered, both students and faculty began abandoning the school. Yet against all odds, Korean Minjok Leadership Academy endured, refusing to compromise its revolutionary mission.



Heroes of Minsa: Dorm Supervisor Mr. Daeki Kim

Junwoo Lee

You wouldn't expect to find a hero in slippers, patrolling a dorm hallway without any footsteps. But sometimes, heroes show up in the most unexpected places – like our dormitory supervisor, Deaki Kim. He wasn't always the quiet guardian of the third-floor hallway. In his life before KMLA, he was a Marine – used to drills, discipline, mission orders, all the work. He lived in a world where obedience wasn't optional. And yet, somehow, he ended up here: a school where opening a can of coffee is basically an evening prayer.

Ordinary World:
His Former Life as a Marine

Ordinary World establishes the hero's status quo before the adventure begins. For supervisor Kim, this world was one of precision, discipline, and unwavering command authority – a world shaped by decades of naval service that would seem almost impossibly distant from the hallways of a dorm.

Mr. Kim's journey started at the Korea Naval Academy, where they had a simple philosophy: take teenagers and turn them into people who can make life-or-death decisions while seasick. The training wasn't just about learning to salute properly – though there was plenty of that. It was about ship maintenance at 3 AM, and navigation exercises that lasted longer than most people's vacations.





His most distinguished command came aboard the RV Onnuri, a research vessel whose name carries profound meaning. "Onnuri," meaning "the whole world" in Korean, represented the nation's commitment to ocean science and maritime exploration. As captain of this research platform, Kim inhabited a world where decisions carried immediate consequences, where the safety of crew and mission success depended on unwavering adherence to protocol. After completing the maiden voyage of the Onnuri, Captain Kim was interviewed by the press where he shared the challenges and successes of the journey. His story was later featured in a national news article including KBS, highlighting his leadership and dedication at sea.



Call for Adventure:
How He Became a Dorm Supervisor

This stage marks the hero's first step away from the ordinary world. It is a moment of disruption – an invitation to change, grow, or confront the unknown. Though it often brings uncertainty and challenges, the call signals the beginning of transformation.

In South Korea, on average, captains retire between the age of 50-60. His case? It was not an exception. When he retired, he faced a new kind of open sea: civilian life. He could have chosen a quieter path – maybe golf, fishing, or writing a memoir about waves and radar. But instead, he took a detour few would expect: becoming the dormitory dean of a boarding high school. At first glance, it might seem like quite the career switch – from commanding a whole ship to making sure students attend honjeongs (evening roll calls) – but in reality, the skill sets weren't all that different. Both jobs involve keeping a large group of people safe, and somewhat organized.

The school, known for its rigorous academics and round-the-clock student life, wasn't looking for someone with just a teaching certificate. They needed someone who could handle late-night noise complaints, and forgotten curfews. Mr. Kim's resume didn't say "teacher," but it did say "led 120 sailors through a typhoon." And so, with a new setting but familiar responsibilities, he swapped sea boots for indoor slippers and began his next chapter; still guiding, keeping order, just with fewer uniforms.





Now, years later, he's become the kind of dorm supervisor who can spot trouble from three floors away and knows exactly which student is trying to sneak unauthorized nourishment into their room. He's mastered the art of appearing silently behind rule-breakers – in such magical slippers.

Perhaps it is time we look closer at the people we easily overlook. To many students, the dormitory master is little more than a background character – an NPC (Non-Player Character) in the story of high school life. We often pass him by without a second thought, forgetting that each night - 2 A.M., he ensures the dorm lights are turned off, and each morning, he plays the wake-up song at the same early hour.

Being a dormitory supervisor is not a job that wins applause. It often comes with complaints, misunderstandings, little recognition, and even insults. And yet, Mr. Kim has chosen to walk this path for years – not because it is easy, but because he believes it matters. Behind his quiet supervision lies a man who once faced real storms at sea, and who now faces emotional storms with equal resolve. His journey reminds us that true heroes don't always wear capes; sometimes, they carry violation sheets to keep track of discipline, enforce lights-outs for minimum sleep, and rise before everyone else.

Looking Back on Teachers' Day: MRS. HELEN JEONG'S Years at and after KMLA

Interview by Jeongmin Lee

On May 15th, KMLA students and teachers gathered in the auditorium to celebrate Teacher's Day. Among many heartfelt moments, one stood out: Mrs. Helen Jeong stepped onto the stage to sing a duet with her husband, Mr. Yoon. It was a special performance for many, as she announced that this would be her final Teacher's Day at KMLA. In light of her final year, Minjok Herald sat down with Mrs. Jeong in the new counseling room for an interview.

MH: Hello, Mrs Jeong. Your performance with Mr. Yoon was truly memorable! What made you decide to step on stage with Mr. Yoon?
Mrs. Jeong: I think it was a student named Woo Seungjun who came to my office and asked if we could do a duet. And I said, "No way!" because I'm not a good singer. "But since Mr. Yoon is a good singer, why don't you go and ask him?" And obviously, he declined. But then I thought, 'Oh my god, this is going to be my last year!' So why not do something special? So I convinced my husband. And we chose a song, which is, you know, 너에게 난, 나에게 넌. And then we practiced, and then that's that! (laughs)



MH: I think the lyrics were quite heartfelt. Was there a reason for choosing that particular song?
Mrs. Jeong: We were looking through several. I think the first song that we thought about doing was... I don't remember the title. It's about... "you could become a star" or something like that? But the lyrics weren't very appropriate. So, then we were surfing through YouTube, and it just came to us! The Classic (2003) is actually one of my favorite movies, and 너에게 난, 나에게 넌 is the theme song. I wanted to change the lyrics. I wanted to sing about how precious and special these students were in my life, like 나에게 넌. To deliver the message that my students were a very important part of my life. But it was difficult to memorize, and we really didn't have the time. So we just went with the original version.

MH: What were your feelings before and after performing in front of the whole school?
Mrs. Jeong: I thought I would be really nervous – you tend to get nervous with butterflies in your stomach and all that when you're on stage. But once I was up there, it was okay. But of course, I wanted to give an introductory note to students that it would be my last Teachers' Day. That is, as a teacher, especially at KMLA. I wanted to tell them how special the students, well, you guys, were to me, and that my years at KMLA were something that I could not describe in words. Then I choked up, as you could see. But I controlled myself, because if I start to choke up and start to cry, it would be endless, right? So I controlled myself and I held on to the microphone and started to sing, and now that's history.

MH: I think many students also choked up on that part. Now if it's alright, I'd like to talk more about your personal life at KMLA. What is it like to share a workplace with Mr. Yoon?
Mrs. Jeong: Ah, yes! Of course, there are pros and cons because we work in the same department. We can share so many ideas, and then I can also ask him many things. As far as literature is concerned, he helped me a lot. He's more knowledgeable in the field than I am. So, in that way, he's like my citadel. Very dependable, reliable, and of course, I can trust him 100 percent—maybe 200 percent. It's like feeling safe and protected, but at the same time, of course, we're practically together 24/7. That's not easy. So, sometimes he annoys me, and I probably annoy him. (laughs) So you know, we get through this.



Photo Credit: @TTL



Photo Credit: @TTL

MH: What was your favorite memory here?
Mrs. Jeong: Favorite memory? I have so many, I really cannot pinpoint something particular, but... After working really hard helping students write their college essays and applications, and then they get these good results. They send me a text message, "Mrs. Jeong, I got into this!" or whatever. That is really something exhilarating, and rewarding. But at the same time, of course, there are students who do not receive good news and get sad, depressed. And of course I also get sad, and depressed.
I guess my life here has had ups and downs. There were some really happy moments, and some really sad ones as well.

MH: What are your favorite classes and lessons to teach?
Mrs. Jeong: I've been teaching American Literature, British Literature, and also World Literature. I enjoyed them all, but I especially like small classes where I have like less than ten students, and we can sit around the table, have tea. It really allows us to have intense discussions. Those are really rewarding times.

MH: Do you have a favorite place in KMLA?
Mrs. Jeong: My favorite place? Can I tell you my least favorite place? The English Building. (laughs) But oh, my favorite place? I really like the road leading to the gymnasium from the English Building, with sycamore trees lined up. I love that place. Walking down that road with all those trees around you. It's just like you're completely with nature.

MH: Is there a book or poem you want to recommend to the students?
Mrs. Jeong: That is the most difficult question because there are so many. But right now, one book that I would recommend all students to read is Human Acts, which is a translated version of 소년이 온다 by Han Kang. I think all Korean students should read this book and come to terms with this sad, unpleasant Korean history and what people at that time had to go through.

MH: Do you have any plans or hopes for after your retirement?
Mrs. Jeong: Oh, yeah, so this is the question I'm asked often... I have so many things to do. First of all, I'm going to pick up hobbies that I wasn't able to keep up with because of work. So I started, you know, drawing, and eventually I'd like to write a book. That's my hope. I don't think it will come true, but I'll try.
And also, I'd like to engage in more community services. There are so many things I would like to do. For example, I could teach English to children at the church that I go to. And maybe work in a hospice, to provide some kind of service and comfort to those people who are facing terminal illnesses – something I will also have to face eventually.

MH: This is the last question! Is there anything you'd like to say to our readers?
Mrs. Jeong: One last thing that I would like to tell the students is that PLEASE KEEP EOP! Don't keep EOP for the sake of the school. Keep EOP for your sake. If you keep EOP, and become a fluent English speaker, it will be a huge asset in your life.
And also read a lot, please. Read as much as you can. Just pick up any book just read, read, read, read, read. And you'll change a lot. So keep EOP, and read a lot.

We sincerely hope that Mrs. Jeong's last year at KMLA can be filled with truly special moments, and that even more are awaiting in the years ahead. Thank you Mrs. Jeong for taking the time to participate in our interview!



Photo Credit: @TTL



KMLA'S FIRST FULL-SCALE UK UNIVERSITY FAIR:

From Sticky Pudding to Long-Term Partnerships

Have you ever wondered what it takes to get into your dream university—or what sticky pudding tastes like? On March 13th, junior and senior international students at KMLA had the rare chance to speak directly with admissions officers from across the United Kingdom at KMLA's first full-scale, official UK University Fair. With 16 universities in attendance, students gained firsthand insight into everything from campus life and academics to homesickness tips and sweet British trivia.

Far beyond what's available online, the fair offered a personal look into each school. Admissions Officers shared tips on choosing academic paths, preparing strong applications, and finding the right campus fit. Josh Koster from the University of Southampton, for instance, shared that the top four astrophysics students are sent to Harvard as Smithsonians to further their research. Anisa Atlasi of Loughborough University helped students connect their interests to degree options and career paths. They also encouraged students to email them with follow-up questions.

Below is the list of Universities and Representatives who participated in the info session:

- University College London (UCL) – Peter Muncey
- Loughborough University – Anisa Atlasi
- University of Reading – Danuhua Wu
- University of Huddersfield – Raluca Pasare
- University of Leeds – Claire Zupnik
- King's College London – Rutchna Bawrie
- The University of Manchester – Tom Williams
- City, University of London – Sandy Kutty
- Durham University – Eleanor Garrick
- University of Nottingham – Becca Cheshire
- University of Warwick – Ashley Sun
- University of Exeter – Brian Greenwood
- University of Birmingham – Mark Yeung
- University of Bristol – Sarah Ashman
- The University of Sheffield – Alison Witham
- University of Southampton – Josh Koster



From fun trivia that the first chocolate bar in the UK was created at the University of Bristol, to practical advice on how to stave off homesickness by finding the best local food spots or international grocery stores, each university found a unique way to make their presentation warm and memorable. Sandy Kutty, representing City University of London, emphasized how their campus is particularly known for its inclusive and liberal atmosphere, encouraging students to embrace their individuality with the motto 'Be You!'

Many students shared how the fair changed their perspective. “I was impressed by how transparent the officers were,” said Songyeon Shin (29th waver). “They didn’t just promote—they were sharing both the strengths and challenges of their schools.” Dahye Park (29th waver) added, “I always thought robotics was only through engineering, but now I know I can explore it through computer science or even electrical engineering.”

Reflecting on the event, Claire Zupnik, the event’s main organizer representing the University of Leeds shared, “We’re incredibly grateful for the hospitality at KMLA. Your student ambassadors were diligent, thoughtful, and a true credit to your school.” Regardless of where students plan to apply or study, it’s always inspirational to have intimate chats with friendly visitors who are eager to share their perspectives and insights.



Concluding her visit, Claire expressed enthusiasm for future collaboration, stating, “We hope that BUISK(British Universities International School Korea) will be welcomed back to KMLA in March 2026. Looking forward to continuing this wonderful exchange.”

In the end, the fair offered more than just information — it sparked passion, widened horizons, and brought students one step closer to their goals. We sincerely hope that this new turning point in KMLA’s relationship with UK Universities offers exciting and lasting future collaborations to come.

Vision Trip Specials: East

The Future of Computer Science Majors

Interview by Dongjae Ko

A degree in law and medicine are thought to be the gateway to success for many. Now, with the growth of tech giants, computer science has now become a major contender, becoming one of the most – if not the most – popular major, promising strong earning potential with high employment rate right after graduation.

However, the hype around 'CS' (computer science) has gotten so out of control to the point that if you want a computer science major, you would have to go to a university one level below what you would've gotten into when you chose any other major. What then, are the changing prospects of a CS major in 2025?

We asked KMLA alumnus, Mr. Dusan Baek, who majored in Computer Science at Cornell University, how computer science students are doing in an oversaturated and increasingly competitive tech job market.

MH: There's the talk that Computer Science students are facing intense competition due to the oversaturation of the field – the sheer number of graduates now exceeds the number of available jobs. **Would you say it is challenging to get a job in this market?**





Mr. Baek: Yes, I would say so. When the Covid-19 pandemic started, this job called a 'software engineer' saw a massive boom in popularity. You know, there were videos like 'day in the life of a Google engineer' on TikTok and such, and from that point onwards, the industry really grew. I graduated from college in 2012, and our grade had about 4,000 people. Out of that 4,000, only 60 were majoring in computer science. Now, 300 computer science students graduate from the same school each year. Paradoxically, as computer science has surged in popularity, the job market has *contracted* rather than expanded. In essence, I expect computer science jobs to be harder and harder to find.

MH: What do you think is the cause for that contraction?

Mr. Baek: There could be multiple factors for that. To begin with, the overhype that happened during the pandemic. I think 10 ~ 15% of the jobs that were there during Covid-19 are permanently gone.

Also, AI will take the remaining 10 ~ 15% jobs as well. To elaborate further, I tried writing the exact same code that I wrote a long time ago for an hour. Now it takes no more than 15 minutes, and it doesn't even have any errors. This means a productivity boost, so we don't need as many people in companies as before. But this doesn't necessarily mean that AI will replace humans. This is because AI gives answers based upon existing code that humans have already written before, with a guessing game on which answer would have the highest chance to become the correct answer. If humans don't continue to give information and stop verifying AI's data, then AI's integrity will



degrade over time. AI likes to lie a lot, and we call this hallucination. And their lies are believable too. So, AI will take some jobs, but not all.

MH: Then how do you think that the students can stand out in this job market?

Mr. Baek: I think the first thing you must do is go back to the basics. Back in the old days, all you had to do was know how to code. That was it. There weren't a lot of people who could do that back then. Now, even humanities and liberal arts students know how to code. Then the question becomes: How do we differentiate ourselves from the rest?

There are three things you need to do. Firstly, you need to be able to see the bigger picture. Secondly, it's important to maintain an open attitude toward embracing new trends. And finally, you need to be excellent at coding, obviously. Simply knowing how to code doesn't have any merit nowadays. What matters is whether you are able to solve difficult questions and are able to create complex algorithms.

MH: Lastly, do you have any final advice for students who wish to major in Computer Science?

Mr. Baek: I personally think the bar for a job in computer science has gotten higher. But I don't think that people who really are interested in computer science will have to worry too much about jobs. Computer science is just no longer a major you just take to be paid.



From KMLA to Harvard: Tips on Living Your Best Possible Life

Interview by Jiseo Lee

'진인사대천명(盡人事待天命) 지성(至誠)이면 감천(感天)이다.

The phrase that should be embedded in every KLMAian's heart and mind. It roughly translates to 'Do your best and let the heavens do the rest.' It is also the mindset that Taewoong Lee, 23th waver currently attending Harvard University for his Bachelor's degree, emphasized when wanting to pursue a successful life in KMLA.



Many students here in KMLA would wonder about what they should do to make their tuition fee worth the experience they have. But no matter how hard they dwell on the thought, it's not easy trying to live what others might refer to as 'gatsaeng(갓생, translating to a productive, superb life)' here in KMLA. In fact, it's hard enough to live diligently during the given school schedule, let alone to do something extra. In an interview with Minjok Herald, Taewoong Lee provided his answers to this conundrum based on what he learned during his time in KMLA.

His first tip is to establish the mindset 'try your best and let the results follow.' The importance of studying cannot be emphasized more. Everyone, from our teachers to our parents, stress-lectures us on how maintaining your GPA and grade is important for universities. However, Taewoong Lee thinks differently. Instead of studying with a specific goal like getting into Harvard University

or Seoul National University, he says to just focus on doing your best every day. If you put in sincere effort, results like Harvard and SNU will come to you naturally.

Secondly, he emphasizes making the most use out of class time. Maintaining a clear mind and understanding what has been taught at full capacity is important to reduce time spent when reviewing. To quote his words, “As long as you don’t fall asleep during class, you won’t have to sacrifice sleep to study for a 3rd self-study period.” He also mentioned that when he was back in high school he always made sure to get at least six hours of sleep, so we can manage it as well.

Thirdly, bother teachers with questions. Ask them about the things you had doubts about and make sure that you fully understand the concept before you stop bombarding them with questions. It’s important to make the best use of our faculties who have amazing levels of intelligence and experience in their fields. If you are mustering up the courage to ask them, always remember that they would be glad to have an enthusiastic student like you as their student and would probably be more than willing to answer your questions. In Taewoong Lee’s case, during his math class with Mr. Inseok Kim, he used to ask so many questions that the class officially had a ‘Taewoong Question Time (태웅 질문 타임)’ or ‘태질타’ for short. Sometimes it might seem like the teacher is a bit annoyed when you ask lots of questions. But the teacher turned out to write in his student record that his questions helped the whole class understand better, and praised his curiosity. So don’t be afraid to ask — teachers actually appreciate it, and it can even help you create a close relationship with them.

Lastly, try everything. “When in doubt, go for it.” If you’re debating whether or not to try something, just do it. Saying you don’t have time is just an excuse and the truth is that you can juggle all of them if you manage your time well. He also said it’s totally possible to maintain good grades even while participating in intense extracurricular activities. As a person who managed to balance Mock Trial, Hyaeumnarae, and his GPA, Taewoong’s advice stresses the value of all the unique activities that you can only access here in KMLA.

To conclude, living a fulfilling life in KMLA is not easy, but it is simple. The methods are simple. The problem is making up your mind and implementing it. The simple methods of Taewoong Lee — trying his best, focusing during class, asking questions, and trying everything — worked out for him, and it can for you. It’s also possible for you to have alternative ways to build up your own unique life here in KMLA. What matters is getting your act together, changing your mindset, and living according to those changes.



“Always do your best.
What you plant now, you will harvest later.”
- Og Mandino





Vision Trip Specials: West

Minchan Kim

And so began the 2025 Vision Trip to the West. Obviously, the Vision Trip was more than just a post-exam recovery. It was a life-changer. We're one of the very few high school students in this country to go on a school trip to the United States. It's the most unique experience a student can have. Meeting various alumni in various fields, touring prestigious universities, experiencing American culture, and staring into the mountains of Yosemite, there were just too many points to get the crowd excited. Thus, the journey had been anticipated ever since the 30th wavers first stepped foot in KMLA. And here they were – on their way to Los Angeles.



Universities:

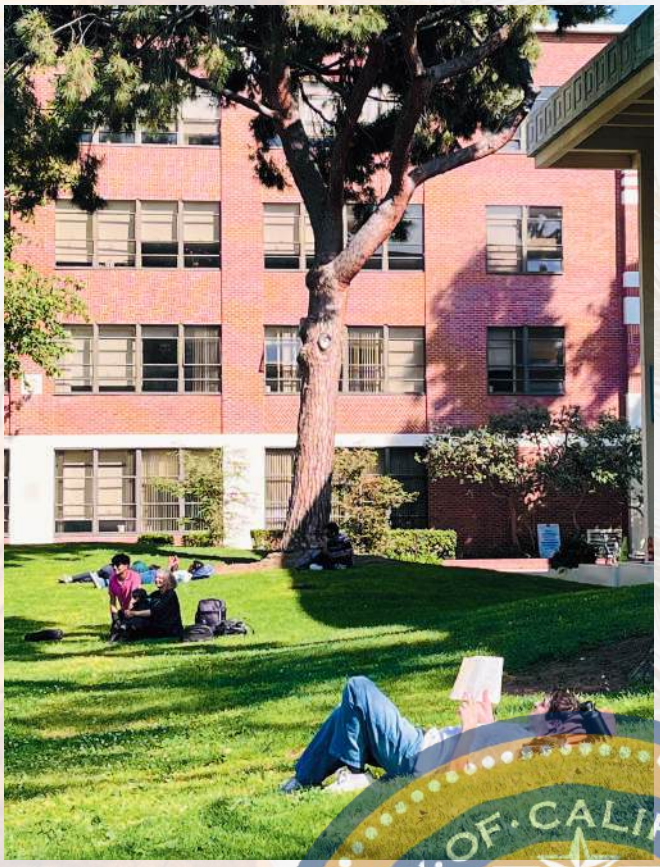
During the 30th orientation period, teachers had repeatedly emphasized the purpose of Vision Trips – that Vision Trips have an emphasis on the word "Vision" and not "trip". As future leaders of the world, a certain way to gain that vision is to visit highly-ranked educational institutions. Thus, students visited many universities – USC, UC Berkeley, Stanford, The Claremont Colleges, UCLA. These are the list of prestigious universities in the West that the 30th wavers visited.

And guess what? KMLA has alumni in every single one of them. This made the students not just a "visitor" or "tourist", but an "invited guest". In each school there were about two to three KMLA graduates on average. They guided students around the campus – introducing each building, teaching the history of the university they attend, and telling students about their anecdotes in KMLA.

The greatest privilege students had was asking questions about their life as an American undergraduate, as a KMLA student, and also about international undergraduate admissions itself. And there were KMLA alumni to answer. Some students personally asked questions while graduates took us on a tour, others used the "선배와의 만남" period. During these times the Minjok Herald had the opportunity of interviewing two alumni, 26th waver Haeun Lee.

Interview:

Below is the interview the Minjok Herald had with the alumni Haeun Lee from UC Berkeley.



Please introduce yourself to the readers of the Minjok Herald.

Of course! My name is Haeun Lee. I was the 26th waver of KMLA. I'm currently double majoring philosophy and political science in UC Berkeley, and minoring in computer science.

What kind of student were you in KMLA?

I was known as – maybe it's a bit of a stretch – but the philosopher of my wave, because I was the only philosophy major. I was spotted lying down on the ground looking at the sky or reading at the library, so I think I was considered a bit of a weird type of student.

Was philosophy a major you've wished for a long time? Or did you find that it suits you after entering KMLA?

I felt like I was destined for it since middle school, so I stuck with it the entire time.

Then how did your experience in KMLA influence your life overall?

KMLA really taught me about how big the world is. I was kind of like "a frog in the well" back in middle school, but in high school I met so many brilliant students in so many different fields. It opened up





my eyes to what philosophy can be because now I'm majoring in CS (computer science). I find the connection between philosophy and computer science, and I wouldn't have done that without the experience in KMLA. Academic wise, I think it really taught me to be an independent student. A lot of high school students don't know how to conduct their own research and find resources on their own.

What's your favorite thing about studying here at UC Berkeley?

Great weather, that's a basic response, but great weather. And a lot of hardworking students. That would be my answer.

Can you give any final advice to the students of KMLA?

Be modest but never underestimate yourself.



CH-CH-CH-CHANGES



Written during a moment of personal and cultural flux, Bowie's stuttering chorus **"ch-ch-ch-ch-changes"** captures the hesitation and tension between staying grounded in the familiar and leaping into the unknown.

Over the past semester, our writers have **"turned around and faced the strange"** to observe the changes – both inside and outside our campus – with curiosity, bravery, and style.

CH-CH-CH-CHANGES



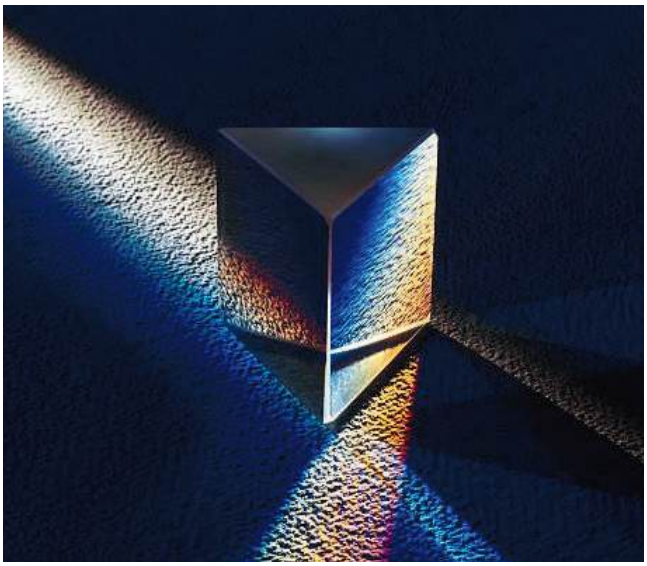
PART 1: LIVING THE CHANGES

In **Part 1: Living the Changes**, we explore transformations within KMLA. From noticeable systemic shifts that sparked debates among school members, to more personal and cultural reflections that are less visible, we examine how change unfolds real-time and how we live alongside it.

THROUGH THE PRISM:
TRIAL AND ERROR FOR A NEW SPECTRUM OF OPPORTUNITIES

Hyunseo Lee

KMLA boasts a wide range of unique learning experiences, not just in traditional classrooms, but also outside of them. Until last year, the chance to explore interests that couldn't possibly be covered in a typical academic semester, came as a Summer Session; a separate semester after the final exam of the first semester and before summer break. For many years, it served as a cushion period between a stifling semester and a vacation of complete freedom. However, last year marked an unexpected change in this landscape. Rather than at the end of the first semester, KMLA now boasts a Winter Session at the beginning of each school year, and with it, a new program: the PRISM.



Change prompts action. It prompts us to look back—why discard a seemingly well-functioning system?—live the present, and of course, envision the future—what future does the change promise? How do we realize it, or prevent that future from happening? Yet, even after our very first PRISM experience in early 2025, we seldom ask these questions. How significant was the change? And have we dealt with this change the best way possible? Minjok Herald investigates KMLA's very first Winter Session, the becoming of PRISM, and the accounts of first-hand experience. That way, we hope to better design the PRISM in years to come; to make possible the true prism that presents our students with a unique spectrum of opportunities to find their true colors.

WHY PRISM?

To begin with, Minjok Herald interviewed the headmaster for the reason behind the shift from a Summer Session to PRISM. We learned that the change was tied to a bigger problem than just the Summer Session itself: an administrative schedule conflict. Traditionally, our school started the academic year in February thanks to its (implicitly) recognized status as an autonomous private high school. However, according to the official guideline provided by the Ministry of Education, the academic year must begin with March. "To align with this regulation and ensure proper administrative procedures, from this year and on, we moved the Summer Session to before March. That's how it became the Winter Session," Dr. Park explained.

Then the winter session was inevitable. Still, the question of "why PRISM?" remains. What does the PRISM stand for? Surely, the new acronym requires an explanation beyond the change in the time it is held. Following is the explication of the acronym that made its official debut in the August edition of KMLA Parents Newsletter (민사고 가정통신문, 2024학년도 8월호).

Prep	Preparation for standardized examination
Research	Individual research and thesis writing opportunities
Internship	Internship & Career exploring opportunities
Social Service	Social service and volunteer activities on- and off- campus
Movement	Sports club training and state championship preparations

When we asked the biggest distinction between the Summer Session and the PRISM, Dr. Park further explained: “while preserving the benefits of the existing Summer Session, where a variety of short-term courses are offered and students’ participation in internships outside of the school happen, the school tried to complement it with additional opportunities, like research opportunities, some volunteer activities, and exercises.”

So that’s how the first-ever PRISM began when students returned to school in early February of 2025 after winter break. Despite some confusions in the class schedules in the early PRISM period, in general, the month passed without much havoc, seemingly a smooth transition to the new semester. However, let us also look beyond the surface-level administrative success and inquire about the fundamentals. One, did our students overall learn and earn more from the PRISM? And two, did the PRISM achieve all it had promised?

CHANGES & CHALLENGES AHEAD

In the absence of any official post-PRISM survey, Minjok Herald conducted an online survey asking students (the 28th and 29th wavers who experienced their first PRISM) for their evaluation of the Winter Session. The result showed a mixed student perception of the new system.

On a positive note, many students regarded the unique classes free from the pressure of getting good grades as an important aspect of the Winter Session. Still, while this may be a much-deserved praise, it is still not a distinctive feature of PRISM. In fact, Summer Session also hosted a wide and various range of elective courses for students without the pressure of a grade. Then was PRISM different, after all?

1. PROMISE VS. REALITY

According to the preliminary list of 96 PRISM courses in 2025,

- Thirty-one were "Prep"-oriented (for standard exams like SAT, AP, K-SAT) (24%),
- Eleven fell under “Research” (11%),
- Only two were categorized as “Movement” (2%),
- While the vast majority remained lecture-based courses that explored niche themes outside the ordinary high school curriculum such as Graphic Novels reading, Basic German, and Excel Coding classes (55%)

While these courses offer great edutainment that many students desired, the core and truly revolutionary promises of PRISM were underrepresented: Internship, and Social Services. “We originally hoped that teachers would take the initiative to plan diverse programs in line with these goals,” Dr. Park explained. “While the school was open to such requests, there weren’t many from teachers.” Here we are left with the question: why? Is this a result of lack of promotion or communication with the teachers about PRISM? The difficulty to prepare such lessons for the teachers? Or perhaps even a lack of demand from the students?

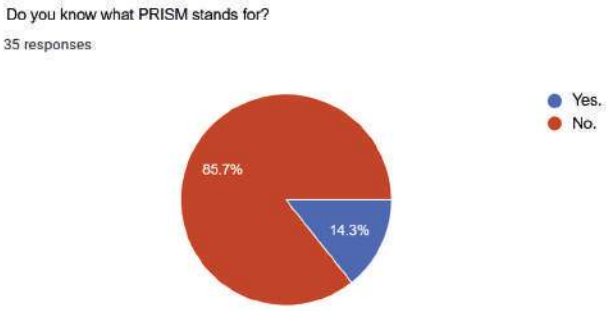
2. IS THE PRISM FOR EVERYONE?

A few students also praised the timeliness of PRISM; how it served as a nice transitory period to adapt into the schedules of the new school year. While this benefit is undeniable, the change in the system also caused schedule challenges and conflicts. Since the semester is now reduced by a month, many class schedules had to be squeezed to fit into the pre-existing yearly curriculum and schedule, inevitably resulting in more rushed classes.

However, the survey revealed a bigger layer of this conflict, especially for international students. Many international internships and competitions take place between May and July. In the past, students could utilize the Summer Session to participate in external summer camps, internships, and contests. But now, with the Summer Session gone, these opportunities often collide with official school days and final exams and are thus becoming more limited.

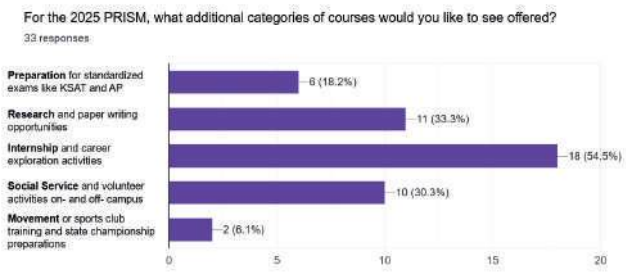
TURNING CHANGES INTO CHANCES

But if the change is inevitable and irreversible, what can we do about it? This article isn't to argue that we should go back to the old Summer Session days. No – this article is to ask what we can do with the change: are we doing enough to squeeze all the cream out of the opportunities that PRISM promises? Are we even aware of what is possible? The survey reveals otherwise. More than 85% of the students responded that they didn't know what PRISM stands for.



[fig 1]

This matters because whether we recognize our options makes a great difference. In the same survey, when the students were then presented with what each letter stood for, many recognized the lack or the absence of the originally intended "research," "internship," or "social service" options. Furthermore, they responded that they would like more of these invaluable hands-on opportunities outside of school. Then it becomes clear that it's not the issue of lack of student demand for such opportunities.



[fig 2]

However, there is a caveat. All these opportunities are impossible without the support from the faculty members of KMLA, as well as active funding—both resource-wise, and opportunity-wise—from the school. They require an intimate collaboration between the students, the school, and the teachers.

During the interview, when Minjok Herald surfaced the concern of now-limited summer resources for international students to the headmaster, he responded that the PRISM was designed to provide a wider set of opportunities for internships, preparatory courses for the standardized exams, and social services, to compensate for the limitations caused by it.

As the foundations have been laid, now it is up to us students, teachers, and the school to collaborate in making this initiative meaningful and effective; to build a true prism on that ground. One possible approach could be building stronger networks with KMLA alumni, startups or universities to secure more concrete internship or research opportunities in February. By solidifying, these partnerships will enable new chances, not just from a college perspective, but for the sake of authentic, impressionable experiences for more students. Of course, it won't be an easy and quick process. But ultimately, it is a necessary step for PRISM to be a true prism, an instrument we can use to discover our passions and enrich the vibrant hues of our unique colors.

Discipline or Distrust?

What the Dasan Study Period Taught Us

Jiseo Lee

When the bell for the last period rings, most students hike up the mountain to Deokgo House, vowing never to see Dasan or Chungmu for the rest of their day — only to hike back down to Dasan Hall just an hour and a half later for a mandatory self-study period. This was the reality for the 30th wavers for two and a half months. Though it was an attempt by the school to provide a better learning environment and an opportunity to learn self discipline, this tiresome journey started from the very start of their KMLAian journey in February just until their Vision Trip in May.

The Dasan self-study period was introduced to encourage healthier study habits by providing students with a structured and distraction-free environment. Designed originally as a 100-day initiative, the policy aimed to build self-discipline and improve academic focus through consistency and routine. In theory, it was a carefully considered effort to support students — but in practice, it met with mixed responses.

Since what started as a simple new attempt at fostering more self-controlled students had possibilities to stretch into a project with no end in sight, frustration was growing among students. Many thought that their concerns — ranging from physical fatigue to doubts about its actual effectiveness — had been completely ignored by the school, leading to conflicts between the student body and the administration over how students should be taught to study. As this division grew, so did the sense of disconnection between the student body and the administration. Until today, even when Dasan self study policy has come to an end, the view of Dasan Self Study varies, while many students lost trust in the school due to their one-sided policy making, others thought that the school board did what they must do when it came to enhancing student study abilities and felt indifferent about the issue.

But let's address the elephant in the room: did it actually work out?



Is Studying in Dasan Effective?

The answers varied from teachers to students. Most teachers thought this policy was a foolproof way to develop student's self-discipline, while most students were worn out by the extreme methods the school used to keep them in check. This difference in opinion sparked a disagreement between the two stakeholders about the policy. Students primarily thought that studying in Dasan Hall just added more pressure to the fact that they had to study hard, which soon became a demotivating factor.

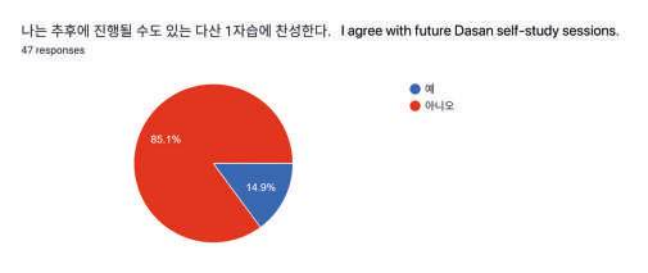
A Minjok Herald survey conducted through Facebook two months after the policy got canceled showed more specific reasons of why students thought the policy was ineffective. To summarize, while some students admitted they did get more work done in Dasan Hall, many expressed that the stress, the long-term ineffectiveness, and the limitations in studying methods added more burden to the student's studying abilities than improving it.

First, the mental pressure. 63.8% of the students self-evaluated themselves to have worked hard during the Dasan self study period. Nonetheless, over 76% of students felt pressured by the requirement to study in Dasan Hall. This likely comes from the confined and surveillant environment of Dasan Hall, where students were constantly visible to one another — aware of how others were studying and, in turn, conscious of being observed themselves. This shows that even if this policy increased studying hours, it led to worsening the student's mental health and their motivation to study.

Second, the inability to increase long-term study abilities. When asked the question of 'Do you think Dasan self study positively influenced your ability to study in the long-run,' over 76% of the students respond 'No.' This statistic suggests that Dasan self-study periods didn't impact students' long term study habits like they intended to and, in the end, failed their terminal goal.

Third, limited ways of studying. 82% of the students believed that Dasan self-study limited their ways of studying, and 84% responded that they can study subjects with personalized methods that fit them better in Deokgo. It seems like this fact is supported by student interviews stating that students, when studying in Deokgo, could outreach more by conducting club activities and by discussing with study groups.

Ultimately when asked the question, 'Do you think Dasan self study should be continued?' 84.8% responded 'No,' providing following reasons: violations of student's rights to study autonomously, limited studying methods, wasted time spent going up and down the buildings, and more.



<fig 1>

A Deeper Problem: Disconnection and distrust

Prompted by student dissatisfaction with the policy's effectiveness, a deeper and more lasting issue began to emerge: the growing disconnection between students and the school administration.

Many students felt that the policy was implemented without genuine consideration for their voices, and that their personal learning styles, preferences, and well-being were overlooked. Even if many students argued that the Dasan self-study needed to be supplemented, the school waved away their appeal and continued their policy without amendments.

This created a sense of being controlled rather than supported — as if the school didn't trust them to take responsibility for their own learning. Over time, this led to a breakdown in mutual respect. Even after the policy ended, many students felt unheard and undervalued, and expressed doubts about whether the administration truly passes policies that are needed for the students.



Student vs Teachers: Divided Perspectives

The conflict between those who agree or disagree with this policy deepens when we look at individual opinions.

Teachers emphasized the importance of discipline, claiming that a certain level of discomfort is essential for growth. Many who supported the policy explained that the 30th wave was meant to start a shift — a turning point where the school would begin taking stronger measures to prepare students for standardized testing and other academic demands.

However, a small number of teachers did express concern, saying that it was unfortunate to see students confined to small rooms, studying in silence. They believed students should be trusted to manage their own behavior and exercise self-discipline.

Interviews with students were more unified. Most revealed strong dissatisfaction, especially among those who feel micromanaged or forced into routines that don't suit them. Anonymous 30th wavers shared the opinion that while it was true that Dasan self study helped increase certain student's concentration and establish an academic atmosphere at the beginning of the semester, the whole purpose of the program became meaningless the moment the study periods were managed by teachers and other students from the department of education. They expressed discontent that the whole purpose of a study period was to grow responsibility of studying alone, but the fact that it had to be watched over made it feel like the school didn't trust them to do well on their own.

Furthermore, they expressed worries that by assigning the supervision role to the Department of Education, they would take away valuable study time from second-year students. In this case, the problem would be that this policy negatively affects multiple grades, including the 29th wavers.

They commonly ended their statement by stressing how these problems must be addressed and improved if the school decides that the policy would be reinstated in the future to 31st wavers.

So, What Now?

Nobody is denying that study habits matter. But students have continuously wondered if forcing everyone into one mold is the best way to foster independence. Perhaps in the future, there's a middle ground that can preserve the spirit of Dasan study without turning it into a daily endurance test.

At the end of the day, it is clear that Dasan self-study had both pros and cons. While it did provide a quiet, focused space, it also imposed a rigid structure on students who may need more flexibility when studying. In upcoming days, the school should reconsider if this policy best fits our own students when choosing to implement this policy again to the 31st wavers. If they decide to reinstate it, to make this policy work in the long run, the school must consider new adaptations: providing options for location, shortening the time period, making it optional, and most importantly, allowing room for student feedback on its development.

If we truly want to foster independent learners in the future, KMLA must also teach the value of autonomy, not a cookie-cutter discipline. Trusting the students — especially when they're calling for better balance — is essential.

Any change can be experimental in nature. But if that change is meant to be actual and not just hypothetical, it must be built on respect for real-life experiences and feedback. The Dasan self-study policy brought a major shift to students' daily lives, yet their perspectives were largely left out of the process. We must learn from this experience that with the absence of mutual respect and collaboration, change doesn't create progress, but disconnection. The key to preventing and solving this disconnection lies in rebuilding trust through genuine collaboration.

CANCEL CULTURE: ROBBING THE CHANCE FOR CHANGE



Jeongheon Lee

88 months. Over 7 years. That's the time it took for a superstar to heal from the world. On October 31st of 2024, G-Dragon made his long-awaited comeback to the music scene, like a ghost on Halloween, back from the dead, reclaiming the pinnacle as the king of K-pop. Well, what caused him to become a ghost in the first place? Why was all the spookiness surrounding his comeback, the mystery of his whereabouts, of the hiatus needed? Because the killer never left the crime scene. Cancel culture is still running free in society, and GD is just one of many victims. Cancel culture refers to the culture where an individual is 'canceled,' or in other words, boycotted and ostracized by society, because the individual's words or actions are deemed problematic. Healthy criticism is good for society, as reasonable and rational feedback can help a person grow. Cancel culture differs from this in the aspect that the 'feedbacks' are not aimed at helping the person develop, rather at making it impossible for a person to do so through dramatic condemnation. This social phenomenon seeps into KMLA, too; rather, it is manifested by it.



Solutions are of urgent need. Cancel culture continues its manhunt both in society and KMLA; it's time the culture changed.

Or is it? Is cancel culture really a negative thing? How does it differ from healthy criticism? It differs in the fact that it robs people of second chances, the opposite purpose from sincere feedback. Halloween is not only a comeback day for G-Dragon. A year ago on the same date, Kwon Ji Yong was accused of illegal drug use. No physical evidence at all, only the words of an ex-convict. Because of this, the police were not able to summon the alleged drug user for investigation. However, everyone assumed that the allegation was true. Videos showcasing his supposed "drug symptoms" swirled around the internet. There was no internet surfing needed; the wave brought the edited videos to shore. Furthermore, despite the police not being able to summon GD due to lack of evidence, Mr. Kwon attended the police investigation of his own will. He himself wanted the drug test results to come out as quickly as possible. Who cares, though? Nobody cared, and kept hunting him down with comments aimed at his dignity as a human being despite all evidence being against his drug use, and some persisted even after his innocence was proved. Coming back with <POWER>, a diss track that criticizes this very incident, G-Dragon is actually lucky to have survived the assault. During the same period, actor Lee Sun-Kyun chose to end his life due to overwhelming attacks by netizens regarding his alleged drug use. His case ended with no official conclusion due to his death, although he tested negative twice during the investigation. There should be no doubt about the damage cancel culture brings upon people. These are only a few examples, though; cancel culture is harming many more people, and KMLA is not an exception.

KMLA can never be gossip-free. More than 450 tudents live together in a single building, meeting each other 24/7. Gossip does not immediately equate to cancel culture, but in KMLA's case, gossip often leads to such extreme cases. Many friend groups in the school get around to criticize a certain person, and rumors start to travel across the ocean — not even an ocean, a small pond — taking no longer than a couple of days for everyone in the school to have the rumor washed up on their shores. Traveling around water normally distorts the original shape. Rumors become twisted and exaggerated as they move from island to island in the water, but cancel culture still thrives because people don't raise doubts. No matter whether it is true or not, students tend to accept what they hear without fact-checking.

Then again, is cancel culture acceptable if the rumor is true? The problem with cancel culture is not in the fact that people judge based on false information, it is in the fact that people judge, and that the judgment is set in stone, almost too easily leading to the cancellation of a person. Everyone makes mistakes. Even if it is not a mistake, everyone can change. That's why second chances are needed. That's why cancel culture is a problem. It rapidly changes a person's social status and does not allow for it to change again. This phenomenon can also be observed in KMLA.

It is obvious that cancel culture is running rampant both in our society and in KMLA. Well, why is it so active? The first reason for cancel culture is the increase in media usage. Social media allows people to hide behind the screen and not feel for the person on the other side. Since people don't see each other face to face, it's harder for them to relate to what the others might feel or how they are suffering from rumors and gossip. The media also helps spread fake information. While distorted rumors are not the direct cause of cancel culture, they do help grow the hatred because they are more provocative. KMLA's anonymous social Facebook page, KMLA Bamboo Forest (KMLA 대나무숲), is an example of cancel culture encouraging media. Cancel culture existed before the media, though- there is another, more fundamental reason for the culture. People's innate desire for a common enemy can be seen as he root to cancel culture. In difficult times, creating a common enemy strengthens the bond between

people and provides emotional support, which applies to KMLA, too, as friend groups cancel others together.



Then what can be done to solve these issues? The most obvious solution would be to increase our empathy. If we could fully acknowledge what someone may go through when canceled, or that a person could change over time, we would be against the culture. In KMLA, increasing direct communication with more people would help increase this empathetic skill. Creating a culture of “togetherness” would lessen students’ need for a common enemy as well. Less of the division between “us” and “them” and more of “all of us together.” Of course, some may say that this is far from a realistic solution, as seen in the Robbers Cave experiment. The experiment shows that for opposing groups to merge, they need yet another common enemy. Two opposing teenage camp groups only merged when they had to cooperate against a common enemy like fixing water supply, and kept hating each other when efforts like having meals or watching movies together were made. Solving cancel culture from the outside may not be an option since creating common enemies and canceling is, in a certain way, an innate feature that all people have. The ideal way would come from the inside, each individual developing their sense of humane love. This would allow people to acknowledge that nobody is perfect, everyone makes mistakes, and therefore everyone deserves another chance, not a cancellation.

Humane love. As humans, humane love may seem like something everyone should have without question. Whether that is true or not, what matters is that we need more of it right now. In society and in KMLA, cancel culture is taking away second chances like a loose killer. The media does set fire to the oil, but the oil is people's innate features. It may be impossible to clean oil from an oil field, but neutralizing it may stand a chance. It takes a lot of people to neutralize an oil field, but individuals are what forms a large group. People in society and students in KMLA should both remember that everyone is flawed, and that everyone can change. Remembering what cancelling can do to a person, and that it can happen to him or herself as well will be the first step to neutralizing the oil. Culture is what defines a society. And for both the macro society and KMLA, cancel culture needs to change.





Are We Brave?
Are We New?



Eva Yeda Moon

"Oh wonder!
How many goodly creatures are there here!
How beauteous mankind is!
Oh brave new world, That has such people in't."
(The Tempest, 5.1.183–187)

If a time traveler from the past were to visit our world in its current state, she would exclaim just like Miranda in Shakespeare's The Tempest.

But, are we brave? Are we new? Before pacing towards the brave and the new, the different, we must, as a society, face this question and answer it. This article attempts to explicate the timeless wisdom in Aldous Huxley's 100-year-old novel, Brave New World.

A Friendly Overview of *Brave New World*

Brave New World depicts a society in which sexual reproduction, love, monogamy, anguish, and grief are prohibited. The offer may be tempting for those who long to be free from suffering, attachment, and uncertainty; however, reality simply resists the plainness of utopian dreams.

COMMUNITY, IDENTITY, STABILITY. (Huxley 1)

The basic structure of the society within the novel is built upon a rigid caste system, scientific conditioning, and the sacrifice of individuality for stability—the World State. From birth, humans are engineered and sorted into predetermined social classes: Alphas, Betas, Gammas, Deltas, and Epsilons, each biologically and psychologically molded to fulfill specific roles. Natural reproduction has been abolished, replaced by the Bokanovsky Process (a method of mass-producing humans in laboratories to ensure uniformity and compliance). Education is no longer about critical thinking but about hypnopaedic suggestion (sleep-teaching that instills loyalty to the state and consumerist values). Emotions, family bonds, and personal aspirations are systematically eradicated, replaced with shallow pleasures, state-issued soma (a tranquilizing drug), and meaningless but constant sexual intercourse.

In the World State, happiness is not earned but administered, and freedom is exchanged for comfort and order.

Christianity without tears—that's what soma is.
(238)

In this context, the characters in this story serve as embodiments of the tensions between conformity and individuality, control and freedom. *Bernard Marx*, an Alpha who feels alienated due to his physical inferiority, struggles with his desire to belong while secretly resenting the superficiality of the society. *Lenina Crowne*, conditioned to embrace pleasure and avoid discomfort, finds herself confused by feelings that resist easy categorization, particularly when she encounters *John*, the so-called "Savage." *John*, born outside the World State and raised on Shakespeare and human emotion, becomes a moral mirror to the dystopia. His horror at the society's shallow happiness and rejection of suffering highlights the cost of sacrificing depth for stability. Each character reveals cracks in the utopia's facade, exposing how control, even when disguised as kindness, corrodes the very essence of what it means to be human.

Inside the tragedy, we find the means for 反面教師*.

The Real World and the Brave New World

Aldous Huxley's Brave New World offers a highly radical outcome of the ever-progressing society that was and is. While the novel may appear exaggerated at first glance, it strikingly reflects real-world trends that continue to deepen in the 21st century: The obsession with efficiency, the rise of bioengineering like the CRISPR-9 system, the commodification of emotion, and the worship of consumerism—all find unsettling parallels in our own world. Modern societies increasingly prioritize comfort, speed, and entertainment, often at the expense of critical thought, emotional depth, and authentic human connection.

*반면교사; a cautionary tale

In Huxley's dystopia, people are restrained not through fear but through pleasure; a tactic that eerily resembles how algorithms, mass media, and pharmacology shape behavior today.

"But I don't want comfort. I want God, I want poetry, I want real danger, I want freedom, I want goodness. I want sin." (240)

We have replaced deep reflection for endless streams of entertainment. An hour of Reels is like a gramme of soma. We have sacrificed patience and mindful living for instant gratification, as Coupang delivery and Baemin culture condition us to expect convenience at every turn. For the sake of algorithm-driven comfort, we have lost critical thought, allowing curated feeds on Naver, Instagram, and YouTube to quietly shape our worldviews. We have replaced healthy engagement with life's challenges for pharmacological numbing. A dose of sleeping pills, anti-anxiety drugs, and energy drinks is like a gramme of soma. In the pursuit of educational efficiency, we have sacrificed creative inquiry and independent thinking, narrowing the purpose of learning to CSAT scores and rote memorization. We have replaced intimacy and genuine emotional bonds for casual sexual encounters increasingly portrayed as commodities, as dating apps and popular media normalize sex as a transaction rather than an expression of deeper connection. A night of escaping reality is like a gramme of soma. In these ways, the blinding comforts of our real world edge ever closer to the engineered pleasures of Huxley's Brave New World—inviting us to pause and consider what we are trading away.

"In fact," said Mustapha Mond, "you're claiming the right to be unhappy."
"Not to mention the right to grow old and ugly and impotent; …" (240)

KMLA and the Brave New World

The microcosm that we live in, KMLA, is systematically not too deviating from the World State—whether good or bad. For the sake of stability, strict schedules, curfews, and honor codes sometimes limit personal freedom. A subtle culture of consumerism emerges through trends in fashion and tech among students. Even school uniforms—meant to erase inequity—become objects of subtle competition, as students monitor new designs on Facebook, hoping to claim the more attractive ones. Moreover, the utilization of ChatGPT and other AI tools is now so widespread that the authenticity of homework activities is untrusted, and teachers no longer allow typed-up essays—no one seems to miss originality. Meanwhile, intense academic pressure can discourage open displays of deep emotion or vulnerability. In moments of stress, students may turn to caffeine, snacks, or digital distractions to avoid discomfort, echoing the soma-fueled escapism of Huxley's citizens. Hierarchies subtly arise around grade rankings, leadership positions, and majors, creating a form of social stratification.

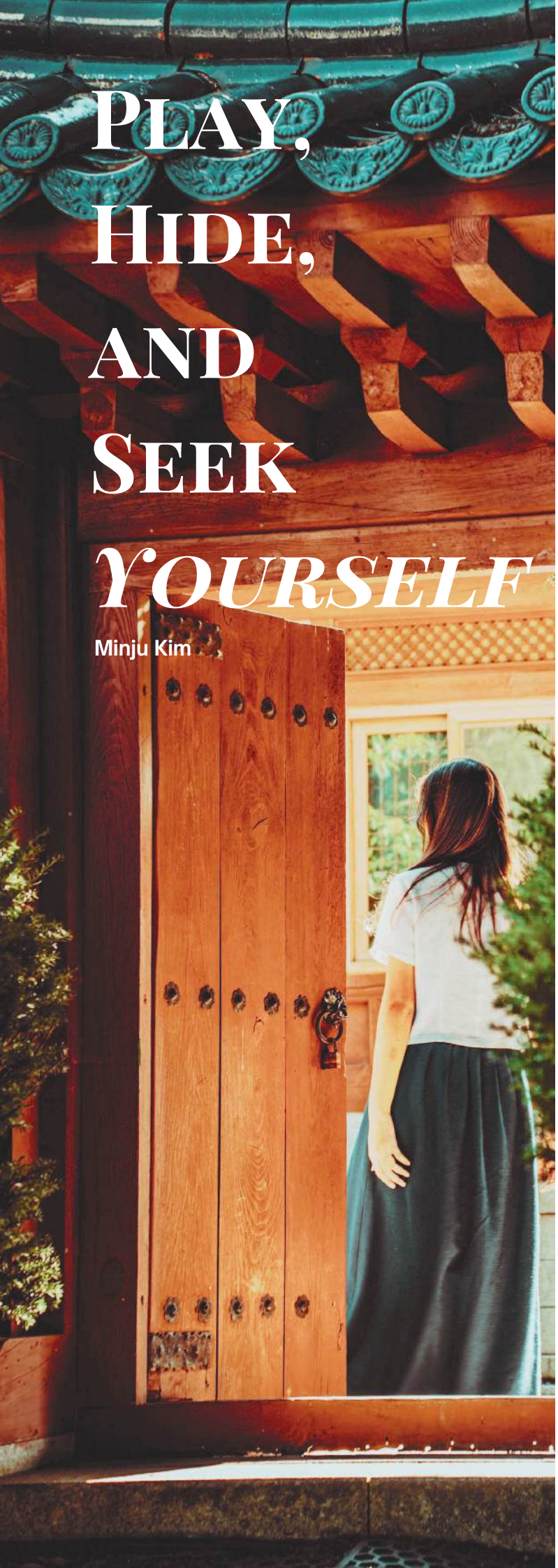
We, students in KMLA, are more like Bernard and Lenina than we may admit. Like Bernard, we often feel alienated from the very system we strive to succeed in—questioning its values, yet fearing exclusion. We want to be exceptional, but often conform to belong. Like Lenina, we chase comfort: through brief distractions between study sessions, through routines that prevent self-reflection, and through relationships that can feel more transactional than genuine. Both characters live in a society that rewards obedience and dulls introspection—just as we sometimes do, caught between performance and the quiet desire to feel something real. The danger isn't that we already are them, but that we might become them—if we never stop to ask who we are beneath the roles we're taught to play.

KMLA, as any institution, inevitably acts as a kind of moral authority, shaping what is seen as valuable or worthy of pursuit. Of course, KMLA does this with noble aims, unlike Huxley's dystopia, yet there is a fine line between what may be empowering or manipulating.

Lastly,

In the quiet moments between classes, beneath the hum of fluorescent lights and the shuffle of well-worn shoes along the way, we might pause and ask ourselves: *Who are we becoming?* Are we chasing grades like Alphas in an endless pursuit of conditioned success? Are we numbing our weariness with distractions, forgetting the richness of uncurated thought? *Brave New World* is not a relic of fiction—it is a living question whispered beneath the polished surfaces of even the finest institutions. And yet, within us lies the power to answer differently. To choose presence over performance. Wonder over certainty. Connection over convenience. In this, perhaps, we are braver than we know. And in this choice, our world remains truly new.

"I claim them all," said the Savage at last. (240)



Play, Hide, and Seek *Yourself*

Minju Kim

Let's sit back and think about what our lives look like at KMLA. Our mornings begin before the sun colors the black sky in blue ink. We step into the cold, running through fog, rain, or snow, barely awake. By the time we return to our beds, the clock often reads way past midnight. Between those hours, we juggle classes, clubs, meetings, and responsibilities. There's rarely a moment to breathe, let alone reflect. Life moves so fast that we often feel like we're just surviving one deadline after another, forgetting how far we've already come. In a way, it feels like we're playing a long, quiet game of hide and seek with ourselves—losing track of who we are, yet still growing.

At times, we wonder if we're good enough to be here. Surrounded by peers who shine with confidence, talent, or kindness, it's easy to feel invisible. But we often forget that someone may already see us as a source of strength. We may not have perfect grades or speak loudly in class. But the way we listen, persist, and support others matters. Staying behind after a club meeting to help a friend, offering encouragement without expecting recognition, these quiet actions leave a mark. A role model isn't defined by perfection, but by presence. In a close community like ours, our steady consistency might be someone else's light. Like in a game of hide and seek, we may not even realize someone is watching, learning from us, or quietly leaning on our presence.

We also forget how much closer we've come to the people we once hoped to become. Think back to our past selves. Look at the classes we're taking, the projects we're leading, and the people we've come to know. These may be the very things we once dreamed of. They might not always feel exciting—sometimes, they feel exhausting—but they're shaping us. Struggle doesn't mean failure; it means growth is happening. We're moving forward, even if the steps feel small. It's okay to **hide** when we need to rest, or to take pride in how far we've come. That's part of the game. But we must not stop **seeking**; that's how we continue finding ourselves.

So when we feel lost, we should remember where we are: here at KMLA, surrounded by people who shine brightly. Their light might sometimes feel blinding, but that doesn't mean ours isn't shining too. Let's keep playing hide and seek with ourselves. Not to win, but to stay in motion. Let's rest when we need to. Return when we're ready. Doubt, fall, wander, but never stop seeking. Because somewhere along the way, we'll realize we've come too far to stop now, and that the beauty we've been searching for has been quietly growing inside us all along.



CH-CH-CH-CHANGES

PART 2: IMAGINING THE FUTURE

In **Part 2: Imagining the Future**, we turn our gaze outside and forward.
How will digital innovations like generative AI reshape fields like art and medicine? Ultimately, we face the questions: What kind of future are we heading towards? Are we ready to shape it the way that aligns with our values?

How AI is Transforming Medicine

Rachel Chaewon Ahn

You walk into a hospital and see a robot standing in front of you. It provides instructions, performs a quick scan, and suggests possible diseases or conditions. While this may sound like something out of a sci-fi movie, it's quickly becoming a reality. The rapid evolution of AI in the medical field has opened new doors, providing faster and more accurate diagnoses, personalized treatments, and even supporting surgeries. Some of this technology already exists; the rest is on its way. Whether we're ready or not, change is coming.

So why does this matter to you?

For one, many of us dream of becoming doctors one day. But beyond that, we're all patients at some point, whether it's for a check-up, a sprained ankle, or something more serious. The way AI is changing medicine isn't just a story about robots or software. It's about real people, how we're treated, how we recover, and who's responsible when something goes wrong. And staying informed is one of the best ways to prepare for a future we're going to be a part of, whether we choose it or not.

The Promise of AI in Medicine

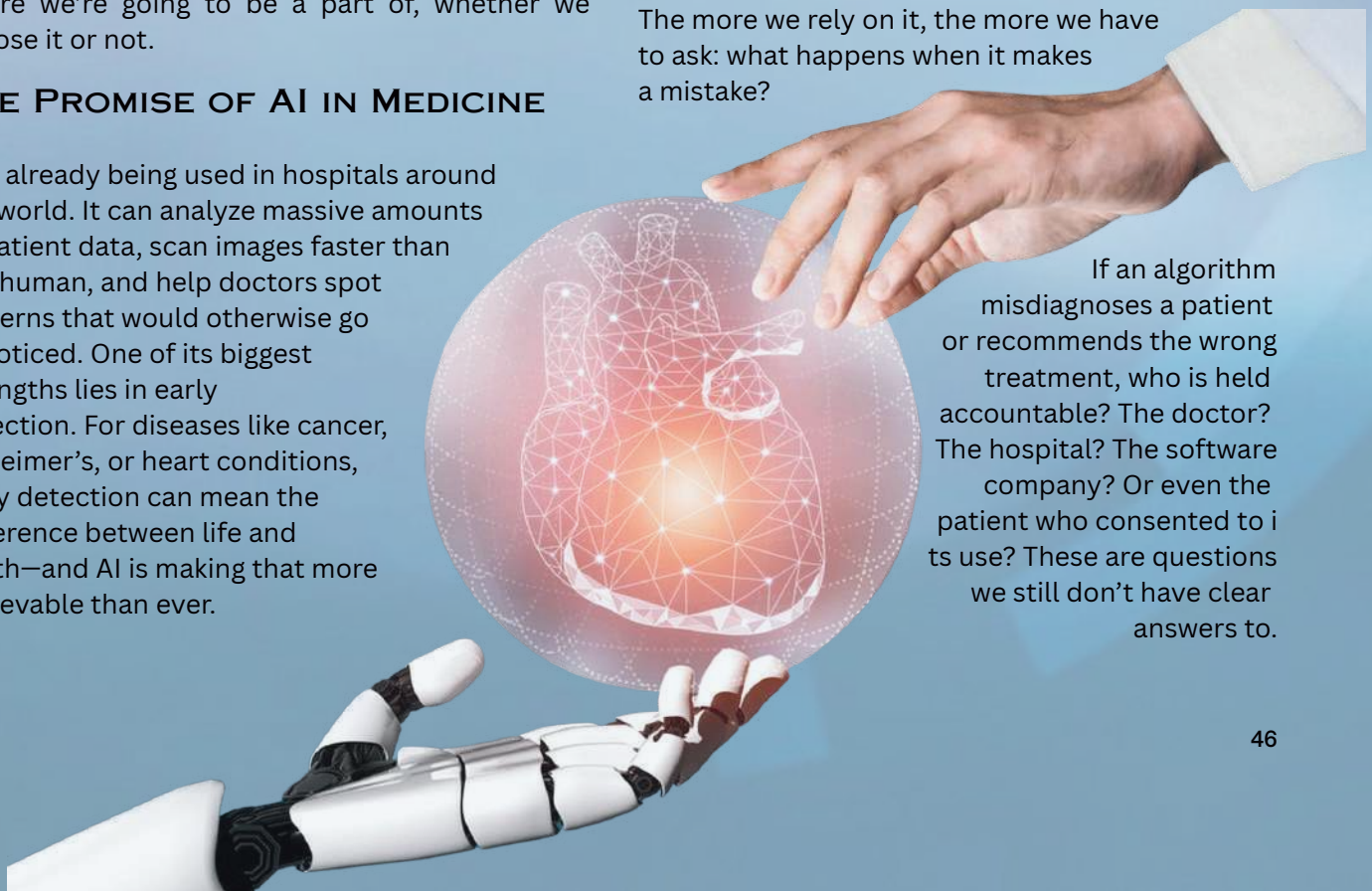
AI is already being used in hospitals around the world. It can analyze massive amounts of patient data, scan images faster than any human, and help doctors spot patterns that would otherwise go unnoticed. One of its biggest strengths lies in early detection. For diseases like cancer, Alzheimer's, or heart conditions, early detection can mean the difference between life and death—and AI is making that more achievable than ever.

It's not just about spotting problems either. AI is also playing a key role in personalized treatment. Unlike traditional care, where most patients receive the same basic treatments, AI allows for care that's tailored to individual needs. By analyzing genetics, medical history, and even lifestyle factors, AI can recommend more effective medications, surgery materials, and recovery plans. What once seemed like a futuristic luxury is now becoming a practical tool in everyday care.

One of the most talked-about areas is AI-assisted surgery. Today, AI doesn't fully perform operations on its own—but it plays an important role in assisting surgeons, improving precision, reducing complications, and speeding up recovery. For patients, this means better outcomes. For doctors, it means having smarter tools in the operating room.

But What Happens When It Goes Wrong?

As impressive as AI sounds, it's far from perfect. The more we rely on it, the more we have to ask: what happens when it makes a mistake?



If an algorithm misdiagnoses a patient or recommends the wrong treatment, who is held accountable? The doctor? The hospital? The software company? Or even the patient who consented to i ts use? These are questions we still don't have clear answers to.

Fully autonomous AI surgeries, while not here yet, are on the horizon. But the idea of a machine making life-or-death decisions raises serious ethical issues. Can a machine truly weigh human lives the way a person would? What if it has to choose between saving a mother or her baby? Programming human values into an algorithm is one of the biggest challenges researchers face, and it cannot be solved easily.

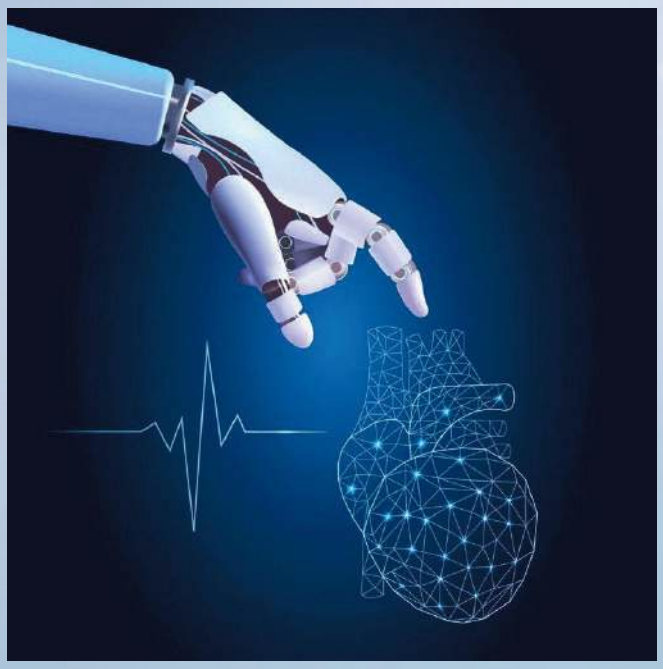
Another concern is trust. While AI can be more efficient, patients may feel uneasy knowing their care is being shaped by a machine. It also risks widening the gap between those who understand the technology and those who don't. If we don't prepare both doctors and patients to work with AI thoughtfully and carefully, we could end up creating more confusion than progress.

Student Voices on Responsibility

Even within our own school, KMLA, students hold a wide range of views on AI in medicine. In a recent survey that Minjok Herald conducted among students, responses revealed that opinions are far from one-sided. Some students emphasized that no matter how advanced the technology becomes, AI should only ever act as a tool, never a replacement for the doctor. They believed that the responsibility for any medical decision should always lie with a trained professional. As one student put it, "AI should only be a tool doctors use to divide their workload, under the same level of supervision and responsibility. The final decisions should always come from the physician."

Others, however, worry about the already overwhelming pressure placed on healthcare professionals. One student noted that "there are already too many cases where doctors lose their medical licenses over incidents that weren't entirely their fault." Adding the burden of being held responsible for AI-generated decisions could push even more doctors away from high-risk fields like internal medicine, pediatrics, or general surgery. As one response pointed out, "If this pressure increases, fewer people will apply to essential medical departments, and the system could collapse."

Whether out of concern for ethical clarity or concern for medical burnout, what's clear is that students are thinking deeply about the future they might inherit. And in a world where AI and human decisions will likely blend more and more, the conversation around who takes responsibility is only just beginning. With these concerns already on students' minds, it's clear that conversations about AI in medicine won't stop anytime soon.



So what now?

We're not fully there yet, but the future of AI in medicine is no longer a far-off idea—it's already here. The question isn't whether we'll use it, but how. As we move forward, we'll need to ask the hard questions, address the flaws, and make sure both professionals and patients understand how to navigate a world where machines help make medical decisions.

One day, you might have to trust a machine with your life. Will you be ready?

And if you're planning to enter the medical field, are you ready to share the responsibility with AI—or even compete with it?

The future of healthcare is being built right now. The way we respond to it will shape what it becomes.

When Towers Cast Shadows : Review of Arcane

Songyeon Han

When ideals and change charge forward without looking back, without truly seeing those it leaves behind, it doesn't build a better future. It only builds walls. *Arcane*, the animated series set in the fractured cities of Piltover and Zaun, asks a haunting question through its world and characters: What happens when change is made without empathy? The answer it gives is stark: division, disillusionment, and ultimately, destruction. In *Arcane*, the divide between ideals and emotions, between the powerful and the powerless, shows how progress rooted only in ambition collapses under its own weight. The show's core message is clear: change without empathy causes division, not real progress.

Piltover and Zaun are two cities, yet one body: stacked, tangled, and tragically inseparable. Above, Piltover soars with gleaming towers, sunlight, and symphonies of invention. It prides itself as the City of Progress, where scholars, inventors, and enforcers work in harmony to shape the future. Every building is polished, every law enforced, every discovery praised. But below, in the shadows of those towers, Zaun chokes on Piltover's progress. A smog-cloaked undercity of rusted pipes, leaking chemicals, and shattered dreams, where survival is currency and hope is rationed.





But the real divide isn't just physical. It's emotional, ideological, and generational. Piltover believes in order and superiority. Its citizens speak of meritocracy while living in blind comfort, ignoring the cries from Zaun that echo just beneath their streets. Zaun, left to rot and decay, festers with resentment, grief, and rebellion. It clings to vengeance and survival because it was never offered justice or peace.

Neither listens. Neither reaches out. And in that silence, fear and hatred deepen. Piltover's progress becomes Zaun's poison; both literally, in its toxic runoff and unchecked experimentation, and symbolically, in how easily it erases the lives beneath it.

Arcane doesn't just tell a fantasy tale. Rather, it exposes a familiar truth. A world where the privileged speak of "change" without facing the consequences. A world where progress celebrates itself at the expense of the forgotten. A world where change has already wounded communities, both the ones up and down in the long run.

This theme plays out not only in city politics, but in the personal stories of the characters themselves. Vi and Jinx, once sisters bound by love, become enemies not because of inherent hatred but because of abandonment, misunderstanding, and emotional wounds that never healed. In a world where no one stopped to care for their pain, Vi refused to accept her sister's change, and love curdled into chaos. Similarly, Jayce and Viktor begin with shared dreams—visions of science that could uplift the two cities. But as Jayce rises into political power, the empathy that once grounded his ideals fades. He speaks of peace, but makes decisions that worsen the suffering of Zaun. By the time he realizes the hypocrisy of Piltover's approach, ignoring and even accelerating the harm done to Zaun, it's already too late. He's no longer a visionary. He's become someone who chooses which lives are worth saving. And the tragedy? He didn't do it alone. Everyone played a part in looking away.



But *Arcane* doesn't just point fingers. It reflects a familiar truth, one that echoes even within small, fast-paced communities like KMLA, ever-changing. Emotional isolation and trauma, like Jinx's, can form in high-pressure environments. Noble ambition, like Jayce's, can turn cold when we forget to check in with the people around us. And the divide between experiences, between those who thrive and those who struggle, is real. But often, instead of addressing the gaps, people avoid them. Just like Piltover and Zaun, we filter each other through colored lenses: assumptions, stress, bias. We don't ask. We don't listen. And slowly, we drift apart—classrooms, role communities, and circles silently splitting under the weight of change. This phenomenon is further shown in a hierarchical relationship, namely those between senior and junior, teacher and student, school and student body, and so on, where it's more than just 'drifting apart'. One sometimes ignores or tries to oppress the other through the higher social status they have, consciously or not. In the end, distrust grows in the crevice as they distance themselves from each other, and as time goes on, both sides begin to perceive the unfairly twisted relationship as a somewhat natural and just phenomenon, saying that it's how things have always been, as if it's the answer to everything.

Empathy is often called the solution for this issue. But Arcane suggests it's only the first step. Before empathy, there must be interest. The core reason why Piltover and Zaun decayed for so long wasn't just cruelty. It was a lack of interest in the other's reality. Piltovans believed Zaun's suffering didn't concern them. Zaunites, scarred and bitter, refused to believe Piltover could ever understand. No one wanted to understand the other's pain, and so they lost the ability to try. Ironically, both sides ultimately wanted peace. But without curiosity, without interest in each other's stories, even peace became a double-edged blade.

Still, *Arcane* doesn't abandon hope. Some characters, through small, often painful acts, still reach out. Vi continues to seek her sister. Viktor questions the system he once hoped to join. These gestures are quiet, personal, and fragile, but they matter. Because real change doesn't come from grand speeches or technology alone. It begins in the quiet decision to listen, to care, to see the person next to you. The same applies to school life. Progress in a community doesn't require massive reform. It starts with paying attention to those around us while we put in effort to step forward: acknowledging differences, sharing burdens, and refusing to leave others behind in our personal pursuit of success.

So the question remains: What kind of change are you participating in? Is it one that builds bridges, or one that builds walls? Arcane leaves us with this uncomfortable reflection, and so must we. Because in the end, progress without empathy is just another form of power, and power without compassion has never saved a world. It only breaks it further.





Ghibli_Art vs. The Art of Ghibli

: What We Are Losing Under a Convenience-Dominated Society

Sangmin Lee



Chances are, if you've been on social media any time in the last few months, you've seen people posting on the viral AI art trend: taking real-life photos and turning them into the magical artistic style of Studio Ghibli. You also may have tried out the AI tool, captivated by the soft, round, and innocent art style that seemingly transforms the mundane into the magical. Yet many overlook the crucial undercurrents that run underneath this seemingly harmless trend, and some passionate artists have begun to desperately voice their concerns – all the while the brutal AI giant marches on. Most do not realize that we pay an irreversible cost every time technology replaces some human function; convenience in place of certain humanistic values. The world changes, and every time, there has been resistance. But as many have brought up, there's something about AI that separates it from other advancements in the past. Could AI be the final turning point that we've feared all along?



AI has not been hesitant in invading the fields that were once considered to be "uniquely human," prominently shown in the real-life example of the Ghibli AI Art trend. Yet notice when we "create" AI art, we get the result without the process, without any thought or effort or struggle, and thus the true nobility of self-expression is lost under the misconception that we have made something meaningful. The point is, we do not love Studio Ghibli art for the lovely art style, though it may be a part of the reason – we love it for what it stands for, the story it tells – Hayao Miyazaki's story. AI has skipped the thinking, the story, the message, and has given us only the final result, merely a shallow copy of the original creator's expressive intentions.



Is AI really replacing human artists, and is the value of true self-expression being lost? Perhaps, and counter-arguments have been raised, such as AI is not good enough to replace the top-of-the-top professionals – but this argument falls apart given that the progress of AI is fast and inevitable, but even if this were the case, only a thin layer at the top will maintain their role as meaningful contributors, and the rest of us will be utterly outmatched. A wave of pessimism is washing through the artist community, most believing their role is gone, outsiders making fun of their situation, fewer upcoming artists pursuing careers... But look beyond just art. Art is just the first step, most easily replicated by generative models; all fields face the looming threat of AI takeover.



Along with art, education is another aspect of our lives that has begun to undergo changes with the rise of AI. Here we observe that true understanding and learning, as well as critical thinking, creative power, and whatever differentiates an

“intelligent human being” from a hyper-efficient computer – are being lost as well. Just ask a friend next to you; it is almost guaranteed they have used ChatGPT to write essays or fill out assignments, completing them without a second thought. Whenever some concept seems complex or not immediately obvious, we turn to our chatbot and it summarizes, simplifies, and feeds the concept in layman’s terms. In a mode of passive learning, students are fed the final results where the important connections are already made. Yet we cannot quickly go on to blame the individual student; it is not always laziness, but the absurd system of education that forces them to chase efficiency. Sometimes you simply cannot afford to spend time understanding every concept, else the competition is now ahead of you. And what more efficient than AI tools? Skipping steps has never been more accessible and convenient, erasing the need for even the bare minimum efforts.

Certainly we do not want this passive learning to be the role of humans in the future; we would be terribly outmatched by the even more advanced AI then. If students aren’t thinking of new ideas, digesting difficult concepts, and practicing to make connections themselves, then are they truly learning – or are they rushing to get that assignment done in time to secure good grades in a society devoid of uniquely human roles?

It is not so much a concern about the negative aspects, say, problems or backfirings of technology; rather, it is a much broader observation that the very things making our lives hyper-convenient are replacing our roles – and as a result – depriving humanity of its most central values such as understanding, empathy, and autonomy. The issue isn’t that ChatGPT is unreliable and gets things wrong occasionally – no, it’s that it is becoming too reliable and convenient that the reliance becomes poison.

We make a tradeoff every time a replacement is made, and of course it isn’t always for the worse, but we do need to be careful as progress cannot be reversed. Here lies the problem, though: there is not enough time to think about the consequences in such a competition-driven capitalist society which demands you implement the next newest technology or watch your competitor do it first. The laws and regulations, after taking into account the full ramifications and ethical dilemmas, are simply too late to catch up, and there goes the newest model of AI, the next insane thing that will make our lives much more convenient.

At some point we must realize that convenience and hyper-efficiency are not the goal of life; at some point we must reflect and yearn to do things ourselves and be uniquely ourselves, not just another consumer or user. And with this realization comes the beacon of hope against this macro-scale change, an individualistic approach to reclaiming humanistic values despite the turbulent landscape of modern society. There are still artists who devote their lives to practice and hard work, to self-expression. True learning still happens in small pockets around the world, in schools populated by curious students.



While it may be nearly impossible to stop or reverse the global march of technological progression, individuals need not be swept by its influence. We are still capable of choosing our actions, and once we choose to use the technology instead of being used by it – then it becomes a powerful tool.

Some artists reject AI art entirely, but there are also those who accept its benefits and uses. These artists have adapted to the landscape, utilizing AI to improve their art and restructure their practice program. It is not to say they view AI art as an equivalent to human art or that they attach similar artistic values to it, but technology has found new use within their systems. Perhaps this is the direction we should all strive for in our personal lives, for all technologies. Instead of being swayed by the movement on social media, use it for your purposes – sharing life updates, recording valuable moments, and connecting with people who are not close by. Instead of relying entirely on ChatGPT to produce that next essay, write it yourself and use the chatbot to improve it, revise it.

Another level of change could be proposed; perhaps not one that concerns the global trend of competition and advancement, which is unlikely to stop anytime soon, but a change among smaller societies and institutions. Could South Korea's educational system adjust to the shifting landscape? Is there anything schools like KMLA can do to ensure their students don't become mindless users of new technology?

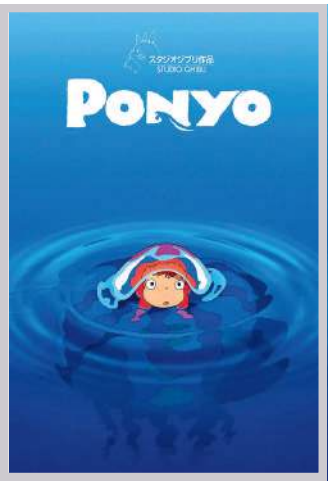
We've learned from history that keeping, or trying to keep, Pandora's Box shut is not the answer. Instead of refusing or being afraid of AI, we must ensure both fluency in use and agency in thinking. Already, some countries are beginning to distribute AI to their citizens. While it may seem absurd now for South Korea's rather conservative education system, properly utilizing AI should be a central learning goal for all future generations. We are no longer preparing students for stable jobs; in ten years AI will be actively changing all aspects of our lives, and we must be ready. Institutions like KMLA, in order not to be left behind, must also reflect these trends. Guarding against the use of AI only under-prepares them for the future – besides, students are using AI behind the scenes anyway. If there is no going back to the time when all learning was self-done, then we must quickly move on to learning efficiently with the assistance of technology, while not losing our capability to think on our own.

Not all technological advancement causes a loss of human value. People weren't concerned when the calculator deprived us of the valuable right to do tedious additions ourselves. Yet AI is different, as well as some other technologies, and they do pose a very real threat to what we consider the "human experience." The cyberpunk movies set hundreds of years into the future are for sure far away, but not out of reach. We must preserve in our own ways the values we hold dear to ourselves, refusing to become just another mindless user of technology. Beyond the charming Ghibli Art lies the even more insightful views and lessons from the artist, and only when we choose to look further will we experience the true Art of Ghibli.









media literacy education
:scrolling through the truth

Seoeun Yang



Today, most of the teenage population lead double lives. One in what is commonly called the “real life” or offline world, and one within the screens. In fact, research shows that in 2020, 98.4% of Korean adolescents owned a smartphone. The percentage of teens at risk of overdependency with their electronic device is 40.1%, as found in 2022. Most students in KMLA check their phones multiple times a day for new announcements on the school’s many Facebook groups. With growing access and dependency on the digital world, information, once shared through word of mouth or through print media, now spreads in an instant through online channels. The most common and heavily relied upon medium of news is new media. New media refers to all forms of digital communication such as social media platforms, online news outlets, and blogs.

While new media allows for globalization, fast-paced news, and the connection of people all around the world, it is not free of problems such as the spread of false information, cyberbullying, growing polarization of views, and more. During the Covid-19 pandemic, conspiracy theories and false health advice spread widely online. These pieces of advice included drinking bleach or consuming high-concentration alcohol to kill the virus. People who believed the information they gained from these digital outlets suffered serious health consequences, and many countries were quickly forced to dedicate resources to debunking false claims, launch counter-information campaigns, and regulate misleading content on social media platforms.

The growing reliance on new media and the consequences that follow highlight the need for media literacy. Media literacy refers to the ability to access, evaluate, analyze, and create media in a critical and informed manner. Given that the role of public education is to prepare the younger generation to become thoughtful and competent members of society, integrating media literacy into school curricula is a necessary and natural process. As much information is currently on digital platforms, media literacy education would need to focus on new media, and how to navigate digital content. If public education equips students with the ability to analyze media critically and utilize it, it can reduce confusion and chaos caused by fake news and encourage better communication. By fostering media literacy skills from a developmental stage, we can prevent future societal conflicts and ensure citizens can navigate their way through environments where truth and falsehood are mixed. This will ultimately contribute to greater social benefits, enabling rational and fair decision-making within society.

Despite the benefits, implementing media literacy in public education comes with challenges. A potential issue arises in the form of hegemonic control within public education. If the direction and content of media literacy education are determined by specific power groups such as the state or government, the education itself can become a tool for maintaining power. For example, if certain ideologies are taught as the only "correct perspective," or if critical thinking is suppressed in favor of conformity, this contradicts the very purpose of media literacy. Poorly designed media literacy education can do more harm than good.

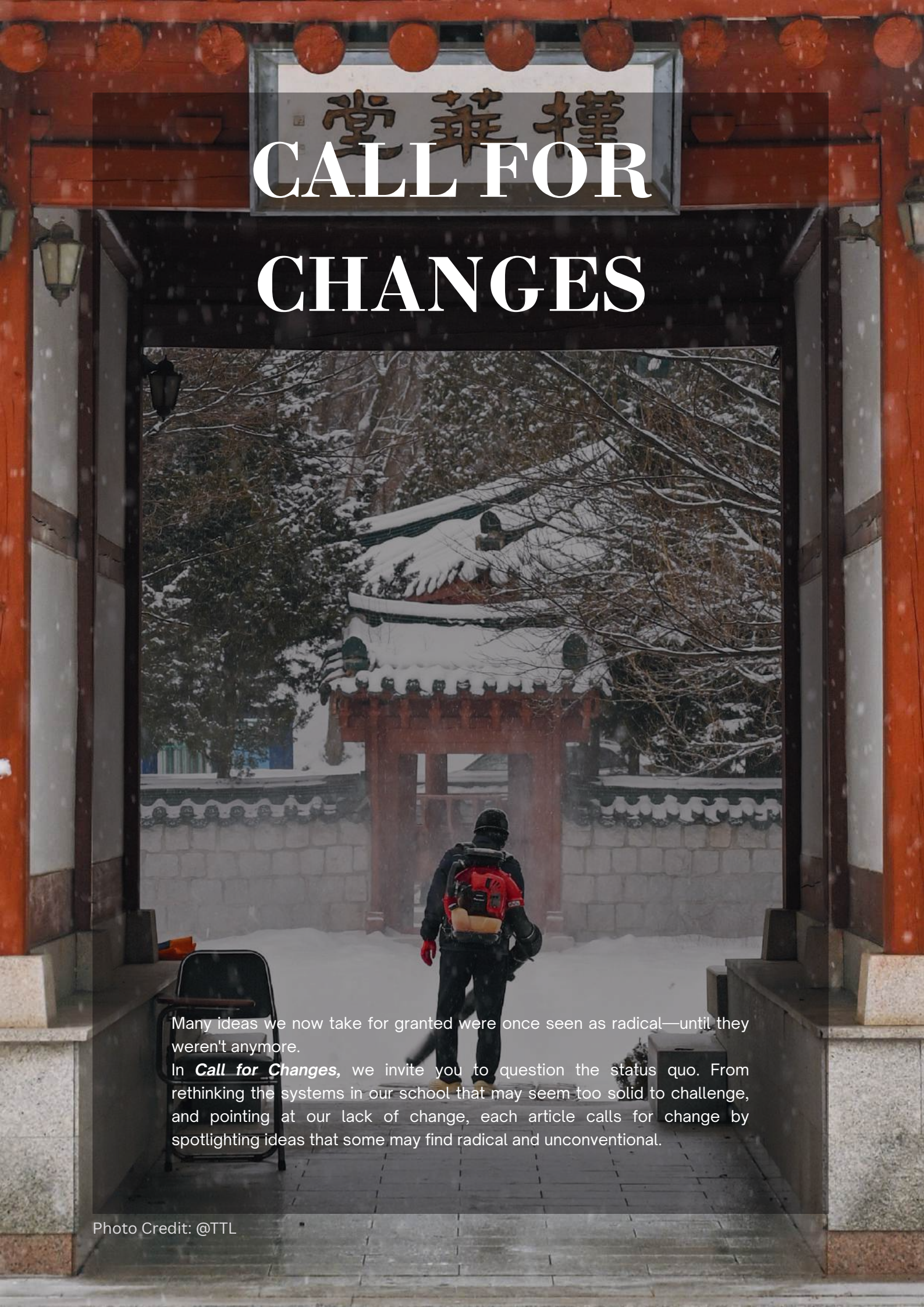
Such an example is China's internet literacy education programs. While on the surface, it seems to be a helpful program that allows students to identify false and harmful information, a closer look shows that what is taught to be "harmful information" includes social activism and criticism of the government. The curriculum deems national news as trustworthy, while information from international outlets are taught as dangerous and misleading. This program does less to increase media literacy in citizens and more to reinforce narratives favorable towards the government.

To ensure that media literacy is fair and neutral, certain steps need to be taken. First, the implementation of media literacy education will need to invest resources in teacher training, development of appropriate teaching materials, and securing class time within curricula. To ensure that the educational content remains objective and neutral, consultation with a diverse range of experts—educators, journalists, researchers, and civic organizations, is needed. The process should be transparent, with clear standards for curriculum design and public accountability for the content. Furthermore, in the initial stages, the classrooms will need to be checked upon to see if appropriate, non-biased media literacy education is being implemented in these classrooms.

Although it is not an easy task, some progress has been made. In the 2022 Revised Curriculum released by the Ministry of Education, high school students will be able to select elective subjects on media literacy. Such subjects are 'Literature and Video' and 'Media and Communication'. These courses are designed to help students critically evaluate media content, identify bias, and understand the fast changing media world.



CALL FOR CHANGES



Many ideas we now take for granted were once seen as radical—until they weren't anymore.

In ***Call for Changes,*** we invite you to question the status quo. From rethinking the systems in our school that may seem too solid to challenge, and pointing at our lack of change, each article calls for change by spotlighting ideas that some may find radical and unconventional.

Photo Credit: @TTL

A Proud Candle

Seoeun Yang

A light flickers in the dark,
A beacon of hope, contrast stark.
The orange flame desperately unfolds its fingers,
Reaching for anyone – anything.
Nothing.

He leads,
Day by day, he bleeds.
From his soul, the flame feeds.

The flame licks his skin,
Bit by bit he shrinks,
And shrinks,
Until he is only a shell
Of the man he used to be.

A duty forced upon him,
A candle to light the dim.
His pain ignored, his warmth consumed

The light slowly dies
As he who fuels it succumbs,
His forever pain numbs

But in the middle of the night,
Another candle is lit,
Its flame flickers,
Proud and strong.
Bright and unaware.
A death for a life,
The tale repeats –
This cursed duty lifelong,
The endless cycle of despair.



Poet's Note

This poem was birthed from a single question:
Why must a candle burn itself to light the way for others?
Our school motto encourages students to light the world and lead with sacrifice. The candle, after all, shines brighter the more it burns.
But perhaps there's another way to lead – one that doesn't require self-destruction.
Why not become something that lights without burning?

The Rigour Gap:

Are the Courses **Equally** Weighed?

Seyoung Lim

Hard workers deserve more recognition. Many universities, whether they be domestic or international, put this principle into practice by assigning course requirements and measuring each student's academic "rigour" during the admission process. Consequently, the level assigned to each class – regular (100), standard (200), advanced (300), and honors (400) – becomes a crucial factor when evaluating a student's GPA. Currently, the four levels are given out in the following criteria:

- Regular: Common courses, Liberal arts courses
- Standard: General electives, Career electives, Integrated electives
- Advanced: Career electives (specialised courses, IB(SL), research), Integrated projects
- Honors: Career electives (AP, IB(HL), College level)

(Source: Course List 2022 Revised Curriculum 교과목 리스트 2022 개정 교육과정)



At first glance, this seems like a fair pyramid: students gradually progress from regular classes to more demanding honors-level courses such as AP or college-level subjects. But upon closer inspection, some questionable inconsistencies emerge. They raise an important question: Are these rigours being measured fairly?

Perspective 1:
Domestic Courses vs. International Courses

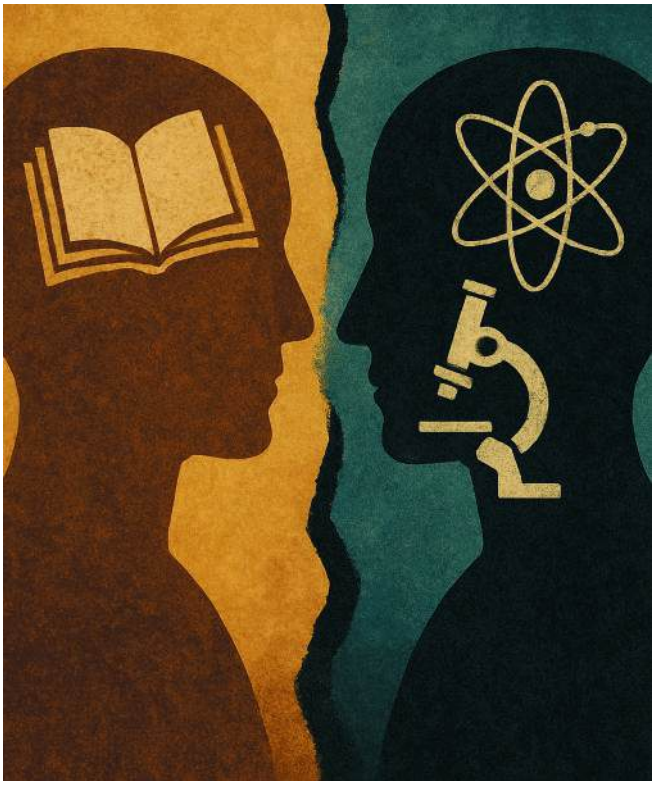
KMLA differentiates itself from dozens of international high schools or domestic private schools by operating both the domestic and the international track. This dual curriculum also means that the school provides classes for both tracks, and these courses typically meet each other at more advanced subjects. Take chemistry, for example. Domestic students typically study Chemistry I and Chemistry II before taking Organic Chemistry. For the international students, they take AP Chemistry I and AP Chemistry II. However, the contradiction occurs here: domestic subjects are only standard classes, while AP subjects are classified as honors.

Pondering on this contradiction a little, we observe a peculiar situation: two parallel tracks covering nearly identical content are assigned different rigour levels. If students can move between tracks (e.g., from Chemistry II to AP Chemistry I), the school implicitly acknowledges that these courses are comparable in difficulty. This gap normally does not become a critical issue since many do not take subjects outside their tracks. Yet, as exceptions always exist, it could disadvantage students who switch tracks or are assigned domestic courses because they failed to register for an adequate course. On one occasion, a student had to take a domestic physics course instead of Physics I (SAT Physics) because the course did not allow additional attendees. Though these incidents may seem subtle, it is no small deal for students since many universities, especially higher in rank, consider course rigour as a critical factor for evaluating an applicant's academic excellence. Simply put, even if the actual courses are taught with the same depth, international transcripts value AP Chemistry over Chemistry II.

Perspective 2:
Humanities Courses vs. Science Courses

Another neglected aspect of the class rigour is that students focusing on natural sciences or engineering find it relatively easier to take more honors classes than those studying humanities. Among humanities subjects, fields that have honors classes are mostly history, economics, and politics. Even those fields run short on subjects after a few terms since most of them are one-semester based. Meanwhile, many science courses offer a constant track to follow. For students specialising in physics, it is possible to listen to physics courses from the start of their freshman year to the final term of their senior year without worrying about what to listen to. Consequently, the course rigour for science subjects increases constantly, reducing the burden for STEM students.

Changun Jeong, a 28th waver, highlighted this imbalance, saying that certain fields in the humanities lack classes with high rigour. “Science tracks have a structural advantage when it comes to taking more honors classes. I took nearly every philosophy class in KMLA. Not one of them is an honors class,” he pointed out. He also mentioned he once tried to open a new honors subject, but the process of getting permission from the Gangwon State Office of Education was time-consuming and difficult.



“Most college-level courses are either science or math, which require several steps of prerequisite courses. Unless you took a science course in your freshman year, it’s hard for humanities students to fill in the gap in rigour later,” Changun further explained, elaborating how STEM students hold an advantage in designing a more rigorous transcript.

What’s the Reason Behind It All?

Why has this system evolved this way? One key factor is the demand for each class. Since domestic students make up roughly three-quarters of KMLA’s student body and have a separate standard for evaluating rigour, they have little incentive to concern themselves with how the international track categorises its classes.

Even within the international track, the majority of students lean towards STEM fields. Science curricula are easier to structure: fields like biology, chemistry, and physics naturally build on foundational knowledge, making it clear how to separate courses by difficulty.

The humanities, by contrast, cover a wide range of disciplines and student interests. While science students generally follow a small number of well-defined tracks, humanities students have widely varying areas of focus, making it difficult to develop a standardised progression of honors-level courses across the board.

“There’s little additional incentive for teachers to create an honors class over an advanced one,” said Mr. Jang Wonhyeong, a chemistry teacher. “I would rather offer a broader advanced class that accommodates more students than to struggle to gather enough enrollment for a niche honors course.”

As a result, humanities students on the international track often become unintended victims of a demand-driven registration system.

The Path Forward

Since this issue is rooted in structural differences between disciplines and student demand, it may not be easily resolved. Still, as class rigour plays a significant role in how students are evaluated for college admissions, it is worth ongoing discussion. Adjusting existing course rigours, such as levelling interchangeable domestic and international subject rigours, could be one of the possible solutions. As such, by raising awareness and voicing concerns, we could be able to work toward a more equitable system that recognises academic excellence across all fields of study.

WHEN PASSION ISN'T ENOUGH

Yeseo Ki

The first big race at KMLA doesn't happen on a track–it starts with club admissions! Conversations center on upcoming tests and interview preparation, and group chats overflow with last-minute tips. While freshmen spend nights cramming for club exams hoping to prove themselves, their seniors are equally occupied, making questions, conducting interviews, and preparing to evaluate the next wave. For many, it marks the unofficial start of life at KMLA.



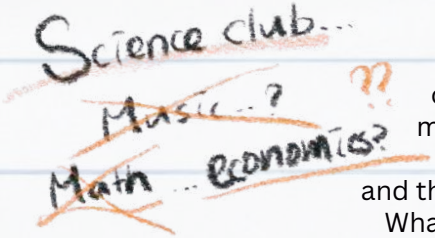
When the clubs opened their doors to the incoming class of 30th wavers, most admission processes seemed to follow the tradition: two rounds of qualification exams followed by a final interview. Yet beneath this structure, something subtle but significant had shifted. In the previous years, the elective interviews of subjects such as 'Understanding of Physics', or 'Economics' in the KMLA admissions process acted as a filter, somewhat guaranteeing that there was substantial pre-knowledge of the students about the subject. However, with the removal of these interviews this year, many students entered KMLA without the same level of pre-study. Here, a question arises: is the current structure consistent with the altered admission process?

When Minjok Herald conducted a survey among the 30th wavers, many emotions stirred up as students looked back on the club admission process – some recalling pride and joy, others stress or disheartenment. Many first-year students expressed concerns that certain clubs required knowledge far beyond the standard middle school curriculum, with some even likening it to college level pre-study.

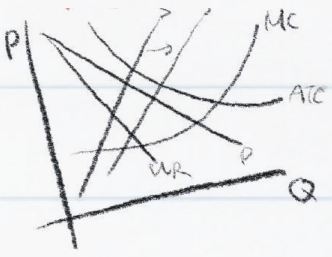
These demanding requirements left passionate students discouraged, especially those who hadn't had access to prior learning opportunities.

Yet, despite some criticisms, others believed that the current system was doing its job. Several students emphasized that the process felt fair and performance-based, which showed that many clubs clearly valued skill, passion, and potential.

One student described the joy of getting into their most desired clubs after a long period of effort, calling it "one of the most fulfilling experiences since entering KMLA." Others appreciated that, despite the competition, applications were open to everyone. While some discomfort around pre-study remained, there was a shared recognition that excellence sometimes comes with high standards and that in many cases, the process does succeed in selecting the right people for the right clubs. Ultimately, students' voices called not just for reform, but for deeper reflection: a careful balance between fairness, accessibility, and maintaining the depth of club activities.



But is this just a few students' concern, or a real mismatch between the old system and the new freshmen? What stances did the 29th wavers, the ones who operated the club admissions, take on this issue? To explore this question, Minjok Herald spoke with the president of a science club. We examined the club's most recent admission procedure to understand how the lack of selective interviews has reshaped club evaluation standards, and whether students without extensive pre-study still have a fair shot.



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"Pre-study did have an impact," the club president acknowledged. "Some problems could be tackled through reasoning alone, but others practically required knowledge beyond the standard curriculum."

Still, the club president elaborated that their evaluation system wasn't built solely on subject mastery. We designed the interview to go beyond content. We wanted to find students who truly cared," he explained. "Sometimes a student couldn't answer a technical question, but the way they persisted, tried to make connections, or admitted that they didn't know were the moments that told us more than written answers." In fact, he believed that the interview was one of the most powerful tools for recognizing both enthusiasm and long-term potential.

This focus on attitude and curiosity became even more crucial after the removal of elective interviews in KMLA admissions. "Compared to the 29th wavers, it was harder to separate 30th wavers based on subject comprehension alone. But that made attitude, curiosity, and grit all more visible," he stated. ***"It wasn't that the admission process became harder, just different. The criteria of evaluation shifted."***



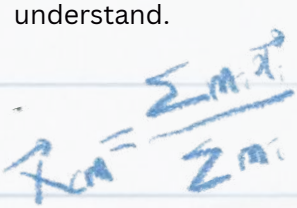


Furthermore, he was also open to adjusting the balance between written and practical evaluation. "Honestly, running two separate exams is time-consuming and not always efficient. I think a single comprehensive test paired with a lab or a hands-on task could give us a clearer sense of who's truly passionate."

The interview with the club's head revealed not only the challenges brought on by this shift but also the changing strategies used to identify genuine passion and potential in changing circumstances.

Something has shifted. While many students entering KMLA now still share the abilities and passions of those who came before them, the path they took to get here looks a little different. The recent KMLA admissions process emphasized potentials and passions over early specialization. Yet, the reality is that many club selection systems still operate under the assumption that everyone arrived with the same background knowledge and exposure. This assumption may have once been safe, but is no longer guaranteed.

To bridge this gap, Minjok Herald offers an alternative proposal. What if the clubs were to give out a short academic handout a few days before the club exam? That way, every applicant starts with the same material, the same time, and a real chance. The exam would still be challenging, but it would measure who can absorb, participate, and think. So here's the call: change the evaluation to match the evaluated. If the way students arrive has changed, then the way we assess them should change too. Fairness isn't static. It adapts. And if our goal is to find true passion and potential, then we must be willing to evolve with the very students we're trying to understand.





HOW TO BORE THE HARDBOARDS

Even Though It May Not Seem So, We Can Change Our School

Jeonggyeom Kuk

"You were the vice president of the Legislative Council."

"Please, don't bring that up."

Breaking promises is shameful.

Making promises to the public, earning the public's trust through those promises, receiving a position from the public based on that trust to fulfill those promises, and yet failing to keep those promises despite all this is even more shameful.

That's why I want to crawl into a hole whenever I think about the fact that I was the vice president of the KMLA Legislative Council. I could make excuses: I did my best, there was no better option even in hindsight, the school was stubbornly inflexible, unexpected matters arose that required attention, and the attempt to revise regulations was meaningful in itself. These excuses are, in fact, valid. Nevertheless, I feel deep regret and shame, sadness and disappointment over my failure to keep the promises of allowing female students to wear pants for school uniform and guaranteeing students' right to sleep during the 2nd self-study period.

In July 2025, the Legislative Council stood at the center of major controversy surrounding the impeachment of the President of the Legislative Council. During this process, questions arose about both the procedural and substantive legitimacy* of the impeachment.

*Generally, the exercise of authority must be legitimate. This legitimacy can be divided into procedural legitimacy, which examines whether "the procedures through which authority is exercised are proper and fair according to established rules," and substantive legitimacy, which examines whether "the exercise of authority is ultimately just and valid in its outcomes."

The actions of the President of the Legislative Council that formed the justification (or pretext) for impeachment brought great disappointment to the students. During what should have been an official discourse with the headmaster, the president brought up personal opinion; then secretly removed this fact from the stenographic record without the knowledge of other Legislative Council members in an attempt to hide it from students. Such behavior was nothing short of "manipulation," and it raised serious questions about whether the Legislative Council was truly working for the benefit of students.

But at the same time, rumors involving several Legislative Council constituents—allegations that they devised the impeachment proposal out of personal motives, initiated the proposal through personal connections, and used individual networks to convince others of the necessity of impeachment—circulated throughout the school in roughly several different episodes. Many students became deeply disappointed with the Legislative Council.

Though perhaps not as sharply disappointed as described above, students are, in fact, constantly disappointed with the Legislative Council. The primary reason I feel ashamed of having been the vice president of the Legislative Council is that I, too, contributed to that disappointment. The Legislative Council fails at every moment. Criticisms such as *"The Legislative Council doesn't do anything," "Problems only get solved when the National Human Rights Commission or Anti-Corruption & Civil Rights Commission intervenes," "The school administration doesn't listen to the Legislative Council," and "It only*



exists out of necessity for the separation of powers in the Student Council, just for show" are therefore deeply painful. It is true that many students feel the Legislative Council is useless, and because the uselessness they perceive is so valid, the Legislative Council has an obligation to constantly convince students of its reason for existence.

Ironically, the Legislative Council's constant failures stem from the essential nature of its work. Max Weber, the German political theorist and sociologist said:

"Politics is a **strong and slow boring of hard boards.** (...) Certainly all historical experience confirms the truth — that man would not have attained the possible unless time and again he had reached out for the impossible."

I firmly believe that the Legislative Council's role lies here. Its mission is to continuously challenge what seems impossible, to persist despite failures, and through this to ultimately make the school a better place. If we acknowledge that this is the Legislative Council's mission, we must also acknowledge that failures will inevitably outnumber successes by an overwhelming margin. The effort to drive school change by continually attempting the impossible may appear futile on the surface, but through this process the Legislative Council realizes its reason for existence.

The Max Weber quote I mentioned above does not actually end there. He outlines the conditions for attaining the possible through reaching out for the impossible by saying:

> But to do that a man must be a leader, . . . And even those who are neither leaders nor heroes must arm themselves with that steadfastness of heart which can brave even the crumbling of all hopes. This is necessary right now, or else men will not be able to attain even that which is possible today.

According to Max Weber, all Legislative Council constituents must be leaders. Leaders must clearly never approach public duties with private emotions or wield public authority from private motives. They must always, always examine themselves to ensure that the procedures and methods by which they exercise authority are proper. Only when all Legislative Council constituents, even as the constituent changes over time, continue to demonstrate these qualities while advancing toward the impossible KMLA will be able to achieve what is possible.

The remaining students also have a role. Fundamentally, we must love KMLA. We must take pride in being students of our school. This does not mean always feeling proud of the school but sometimes feeling sadness and anger about the school's situation. We must want the school to succeed in a genuine meaning that goes beyond college admission results and luxurious facilities.

Only when we all unite in this way can we develop an interest in student autonomy and thus drive change in our school. It is impossible to care about something we don't love. To borrow Max Weber's expression, only when we the KMLA students love KMLA, can we arm ourselves with that steadfastness of heart to care for student autonomy which can brave even the crumbling of all hopes. This is necessary right now, or else men will not be able to attain even that which is possible today.

Some people say that for us to love KMLA, it must become a better place. But the reality is the opposite. Only when we love KMLA can KMLA become a better place.



Facebook in KMLA



Minchan Kim

As a candidate, 29th waver Yeojun Park made a campaign promise to use Discord as KMLA's official means of announcement and communication. It is now the end of the 39th Executive Council, yet Facebook remains sturdy as KMLA's agora. How does Facebook remain so still?

Hello, Facebook

Facebook was founded in 2004, nine years after KMLA was established. Just three years later, the 10th wavers programmed KMLA's own system of communication during their senior years – KMLA Online. For the next five years, most announcements and online conversations took place on the platform's notice page. From 2007 to 2012, 366 pages of notices were uploaded. Compare that with 210 pages from 2012 to present day. That's nearly a 4 times difference. Why the massive drop? What happened in 2012?

2012 was the turning point in KMLA's announcement system. The Facebook group "먹9사9팔9" was created. Like its name implies, the group's original purpose was to buy and sell small items of food such as cup noodles. However, it quickly shifted its function from a simple marketplace to a complex agora. All minor announcements were delivered through Facebook, and even some crucial announcements were made through this page, too. And this was the start of a new tradition – Facebook – and to this day it serves as the semi-official online platform for KMLA students.

Facebook, Now

Facebook is now being used for even more purposes. Announcements of all kinds are included – from a teacher's notice to students to a person-to-person request. Student councils also account for a large part of Facebook usage. All three of the executive, legislative, and judicial councils report their progress and results through Facebook. For example, the judicial council uses the "KMLA 사법위원회" page to analyze each court's defendant and accusation counts.

Also, students use Facebook Messenger as their online chatting platform instead of KakaoTalk or Instagram. This is likely due to the increased role of Facebook over the years. KMLA students use Facebook Messenger for private conversations or private group announcements for departments or clubs.

The Advantages of Using Facebook

One crucial benefit of using Facebook is that it is a social media platform managed by a company, not by students. If our own platform were to be built, students would have to spend hours simply programming and designing a website or an app, let alone the time it takes to manage such software.

But are there any problems?

One significant drawback of the "먹9사9팔9" page is that minor announcements and market activity are mixed like a salad. To find a certain announcement, you have to search through a jungle of posts. On top of that, the setting to show new posts first as default is unavailable in Facebook, forcing us to go through the inconvenience of selecting "new posts" every single time we're looking for a certain post.

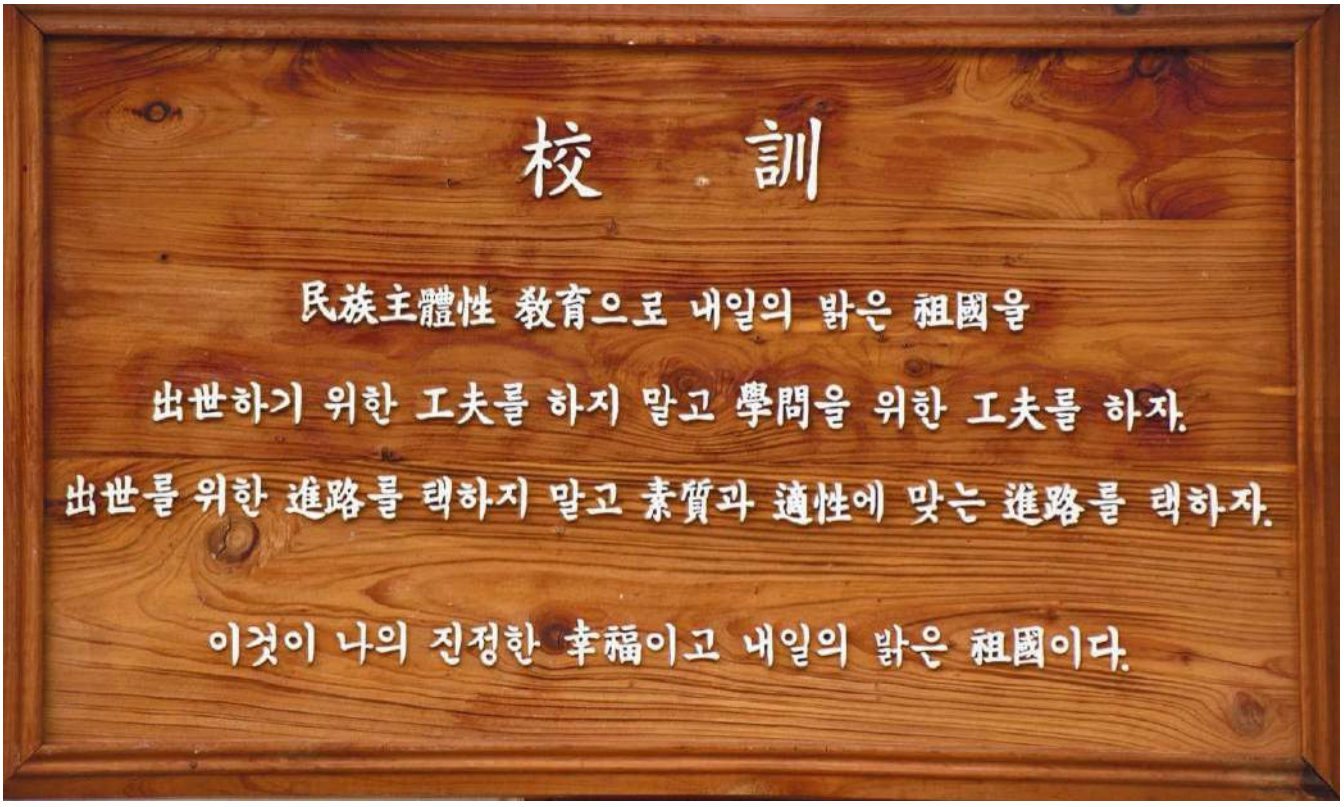
A good idea to solve this would be to create separate places for different announcements. For example, those for all wavers or of extreme urgency can be uploaded on "KMLA 전체공지", while those for more than a group of 20 can use another group, and personal notices like asking someone to read their Messenger can be done through yet another page.

Should we discard Facebook?

Considering the fact that the problems stated above can be solved using the features of Facebook, it seems unnecessary to develop our own page for announcements. A new platform might seem fancy, but it wouldn't be a reasonable choice considering the time and resources it would take.

HOW "GLOBAL" ARE WE?

Jeongmin Lee



Every morning, a total of four hundred fifty-seven students wake up under the Deokgo House roof tiles, rush to morning exercise, and sleepily swear that cultural education will be the savior of our fatherland and our futures. We put on our hanboks and study under the blue tile rooftops of Dasan and Chungmoo. We are taught:

"KOREA IN HEART, WORLD IN MIND."

It's a powerful slogan, and also what we tell ourselves every other day. That we are the beacon of tradition and globalization that will lead our country to prosperity. But maybe, it's time for a re-evaluation of what the phrase stands for—and of what we represent.

What is tradition exactly? Is it something stagnant, etched unchangeably into the historical records? Or is it something we get to shape as time passes?

Let's reframe this: In the context of all that our school stands for, what does it mean to "uphold traditional values?"

As of now, there is a rising opinion that KMLA identity is virtually built on an obsession with preservation. And because of this arises much of the conflict between the school and the students. To put it harshly, we are tradition choking on itself. To uphold traditional values should be, ideally, to carry pieces of Korean identity and history into the new global world—it should not be equivalent to blindly forcing stagnation for old times' sake. So why are we so afraid to evolve?

Case 1: Uniforms & Expression

If we are to pride ourselves in being global leaders, it is time to look forward.

Let's dive into one of the most heated matters: our school uniform. The history of this discussion is strained, and so is the relationship between students and school authorities when this issue is brought up. That is exactly why direct conversation is needed.
When we choose which parts of the past to carry forward, is it for the sake of cultural identity, or is it purely for the sake of preservation? There



certainly are aspects of the past that have no place within our current moral standards, for example, "women should only wear dresses and men should only wear pants." This ideology has been challenged numerous times, especially in the global field, and is now considered heavily outdated. However, it is still ever-present and implicit in our gender-restrictive uniform policy. KMLA defends it as an inseparable part of Korean tradition. But this argument starts to disintegrate when we ask what makes it so inseparable. From shape to colors to fabric, our uniform is significantly altered from the original hanbok of the Chosun dynasty, so it's hard to define what "modernization in moderation" is, to borrow the school's words. So, where do we draw the line?

We can separate the custom and the belief all we want, but we must admit that insisting on customs that stem from outdated values directly perpetuates that way of thinking. Forcing students to wear different uniforms according to their sex pushes the idea that sex defines and restricts clothing; or at least, allows that idea to exist in modern society without critique. Why should something be free of criticism just because it's tradition?

According to a meeting transcript from June 21, 2019, the main reason students call for gender-free uniform choice is the lack of choice in gender expression. "In order to achieve gender equality, there should be equal choice, but many students feel like it's discrimination that for girls, they can only wear skirts and not anything else," a student explained. In the meeting, the student representatives requested that the school remove "sex" as a restrictive criterion. They explained that the strict sex-based restriction comes to many students as a source of underhanded systemic discrimination. Several opposing teachers argued that it is inappropriate and thus unnecessary to apply these standards to what should simply be understood as a symbolic custom. On the other hand, another teacher proposed the question, "What does the tradition of gender-restrictive clothing teach students?"

If we may bring the other side of KMLA's values into the conversation, I would like to ask a slightly different question: What could gender-free uniform choice teach students? To think of a few, it could teach students to view the world more critically, while our current policy teaches us that if it's tradition, it gets a free pass on ethics and should be blindly followed. More fittingly, it could bring students closer to true globalization. After all, globalization doesn't just come from speaking English; a reassessment of values is due.

Case 2: Inclusivity at KMLA

We have several sorts of tasks in front of us regarding globalization, and if I were to choose just one to address, I would pick our lack of inclusivity.

According to Collins Dictionary, inclusivity is defined as "the fact or policy of not excluding members or participants on the grounds of gender, race, class, sexuality, disability, etc." When inclusivity is not provided, there are always people who are invisible. We may not overtly state in policy that any demographic should be excluded, but it happens implicitly all the time, or at least enough to be a reason why KMLA is not yet ready to be "global."

For example, nearly everyone has heard someone on our campus saying the n-word at least once. For a school that has "Korea in Heart and World in Mind," that is quite an issue. Sometimes, it's written in big letters on the board in an empty classroom. Sometimes it's sung and echoed in the dorm halls, and sometimes it's thrown around as something of no more weight than a silly joke. We also hear phrases like "are you disabled" or "that's gay" casually used as insults, not necessarily because people mean to be hateful, but because these jokes have become somewhat standard.

Now, some might argue that this is overreacting, and that it's for fun and not meant to offend. But that misses the point.

One anonymous student told us in an interview that they feel insulted when gay jokes are thrown around. “Even if they claim to have no bad intentions, because those jokes come from the belief that there cannot possibly be a queer person near them, it always ticks me off,” they said. Another student told us, “I wish people would stop saying ‘I’m so ADHD,’ like it’s some casual joke.” These are opinions rarely heard out in the open; nevertheless, I’m sure everyone has at the very least one friend who feels this way.

A big obstacle in this issue is that the idea of inclusivity is often labeled as “snowflake culture”[1] or another rampant agenda of the “politically correct.”[2] This kind of dismissal can block out productive discussion.

Of course, we don’t have to be standing on eggshells all day, but we can be willing to listen and have a little more empathy. That’s what a future-ready school looks like.

Moving Forward

The first step to globalization in KMLA is open discussion, both within the student body and with school authorities.

Looking through old Facebook posts, it’s a bit surprising how much things have changed. In the previously referenced meeting transcript, which is posted on the KMLA General Announcement (KMLA 전체공지) Facebook group, there were more than twenty comments from students showing support for the student representatives or offering their own opinions. There were even a few openly defending the argument that gender-restrictive uniforms negatively affect genderqueer students.

Today, this open discussion has slowed. However, there cannot be productive change without ample discourse. Empathy and honest conversation, from both the school and the students, have to be present or we cannot claim to be the progressive leaders of the nation.
Tradition shouldn’t be about freezing time. And being global is not about performance. It’s about engagement. Because when all is said and done, we are part of history. We are not an endpoint—we are part of a lineage of generations that continues on and on, and customs have never in history remained unchanging.

Why don’t we start there?


Photo Credit: @TTL

[1]A derogatory slang term often used to describe someone who is overly sensitive, now used mostly politically as a dismissive label against young people with liberal beliefs.
[2]A term used to describe language, beliefs, policies, or actions that are intended to be inclusive to marginalized communities (commonly abbreviated as PC).

TURN
AND

FACE
THE
STRANGE